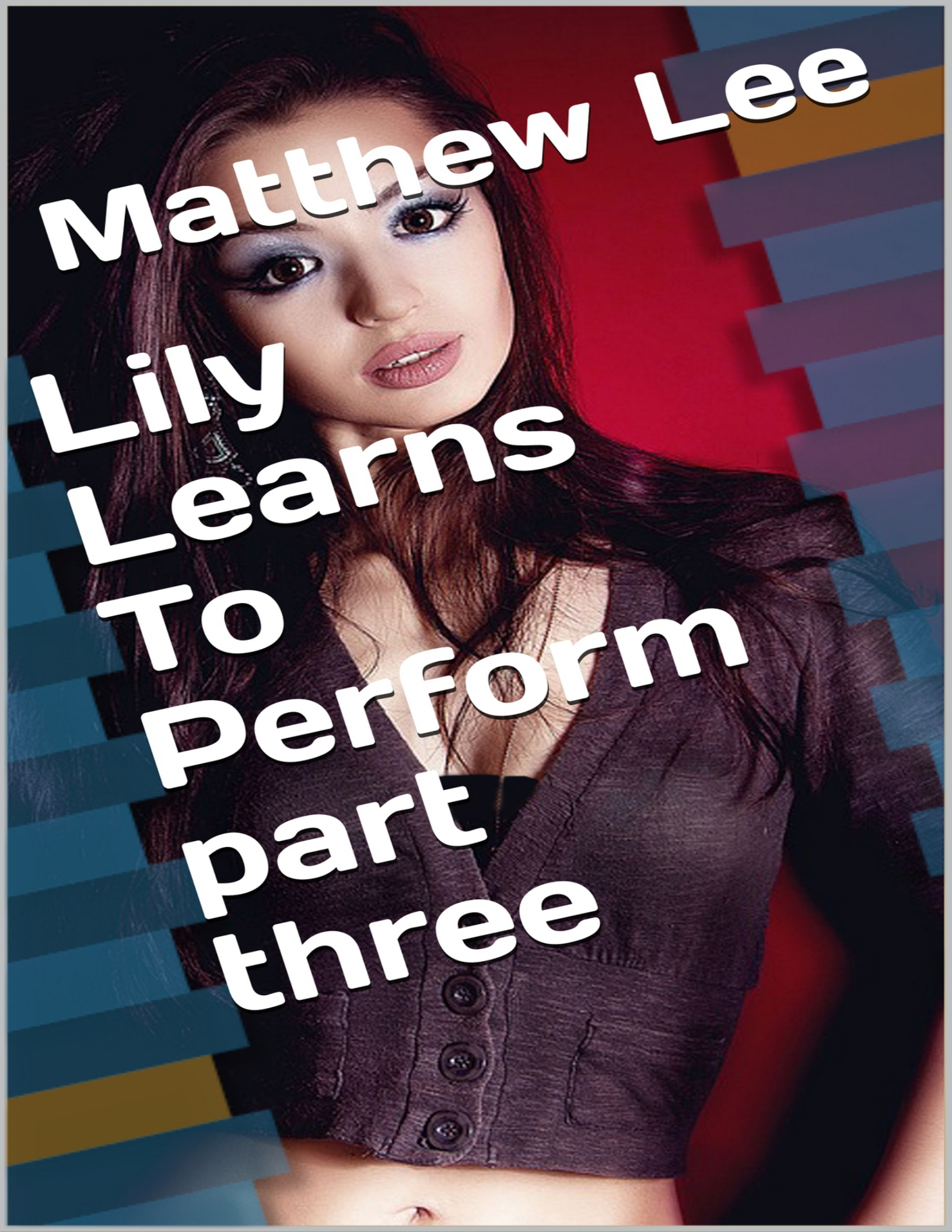




Matthew Lee

**Lily
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To
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three**



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Lily Learns to Perform

Part Three

By Matthew Lee

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Chapter 1

Bang, bang-bang.

The knock on my front door had authority. I stepped away from my computer in the office and shoved my feet into moccasins. As I reached the kitchen, Lily was just emerging from the bedroom. She wore fuzzy black slippers and baggy gray sweats and a black hoodie five times too big. She looked astonishingly cute. In her hands was a mug of hot chocolate.

“Who is it?” she asked.

“My x-ray vision only works on your clothing. I’ll have to open this door to answer that question.”

She made a face at me.

I opened the door.

Winter air hit me in the face.

The man was taller than me by several inches and older by a couple decades. His face was weathered but his sad and exhausted eyes slapped you. This man had seen some shit.

“Howdy,” he said, his voice deep and gravelly. He held out a business card. “My name is Donte Frams. I’m investigating the death of Leo Mason. Gloria, his wife hired me.”

Well, shit.

Chapter 2

In the months that followed our adventures, or misadventures as we sometimes called them, Lily and I sailed through the sky on a rainbow bridge made of gold.

Yeah, I know, but sometimes our life feels like that.

Lily continued to work for Sebastian but also took acting gigs on her own. She was building a reputation as a solid and bankable performer and making more money with each show. My job continued to be as rewarding as ever too.

In *Cleave*, Sebastian's play about the American civil war, he had paired Lily with Dominique, a powerful black man cast in the role of a slave. The chemistry between them was palpable and the audiences as well as the critics ate it up. I held my breath three nights a week for five straight months. There were several topless scenes and one scene of full nudity when Lily caught Dominique bathing in the Mississippi and they had sex on the shore. The plywood scenery hid the naked actors from audience view but I knew what truly happened. I knew because she told me. I knew each time they acted that scene, Dominique eased his firm black spear into her slit and sank his inches balls-deep. Lily's acting was remarkable more for what she did not reveal than what she did. The night the play closed, Dominique came home with Lily and savagely fucked her in our bed and on my lap while I held and kissed her.

Lily and I have come to appreciate that moment most; We're gazing into each other's loving eyes, we're kissing softly, tender and affectionate. We are inside a bubble of pure love and trust yet another man has his hands on her and his cock inside her. The paradox is poignant. It is a moment exclusively our own, made possible by another.

Of Leo Mason, we'd heard nothing. I'd hinted a few times to Sebastian, searching for clues, trying to learn what happened, but he'd told me to let sleeping dragons sleep, so I did. Leo may have disappeared but my lingering guilt had not.

Chapter 3

So, enter Donte Frams.

I took the offered card and read the small script; *Donte Frams, Discreet Investigations*. Behind the type was a watermark of a magnifying glass. Quaint. He wore a blue blazer over light blue polo shirt and from a pocket withdrew a notepad.

"May I ask you a few questions?"

"Sure," I replied, ready to pretend I knew nothing

Lily walked up beside me, sipping her hot chocolate. The cold outside air turned her nipples into bumps so hard not even her thick hoodie could smother them. Donte covered well but his gaze froze for an instant before flicking up to her pretty face. He froze there for an instant too before returning to his notepad.

“How did you know him?”

“Employee,” I said. “He quit without notice.”

“Have you heard from him?”

“No. I thought you said you were investigating his death? How could I hear from him if he’s dead? Is he, or isn’t he?”

He ignored my question for one of his own.

“How about you ma’am? Have you heard from Leo?”

I answered for her. “If he’s my ex-employee, why would you question my wife?”

He gave me a hard but unreadable stare. He reached into a pants pocket and withdrew a scrap of paper and held it before my face with two wrinkled fingers.

“Luke and Lily. That’s you, right?”

“Yes.”

“That’s your phone number, right?”

“Yes.”

“I found this note in his personal effects at the residence he shared with his wife. I wonder, if he was just your employee, how come he knew your wife’s name?”

Sometimes my brain works fast. “I often bring work home. He’d swing by and take the files back to the office for me. I gave him my wife’s name in case I wasn’t home. I gave his name to her also.”

“I see,” he said.

“Why do you think he’s dead? I thought he just moved away.”

He hit me with the stare again but this time he seemed to be thinking I was a dumbass. I held my ground. He relented.

“Blood,” he said. “And lots of it, matching his type. Signs of a fight. Markings that a body had been taken away. Things like that.”

Lily covered her mouth with a hand.

“All right,” I said. “Ask your questions.”

His questions turned routine; *what kind of employee had Leo been? Did any other employees hate him? What enemies did he have that I knew*

of? Was I aware of any drug use? I fielded the questions casually, admitting only what I should have known, and Donte soon wrapped up his interview. We shook hands, he took another furtive look at Lily's big tits and hard nipples, and we said goodbye. I closed the door.

Lily held her hot cocoa with both hands, warming them.

"What's going on?" she asked. "Why does Donte think Leo is dead? That's just crazy. Who would hurt Leo?"

I'd debated for months about telling her the truth but she still worked with Sebastian and I wanted to leave that relationship untarnished by my meddling. I guess I wanted to cover my own ass too. Now I felt I could no longer.

"All right," I said, moving us both to the living room. "Sit down. I need to talk to you and you won't like some of what I have to say."

I told her everything.

I told her how I'd been jealous of Leo and informed Sebastian what his henchman was doing. I told her how upset Sebastian had become and how Sebastian said he'd take care of it. I told her how Leo had backed off but in my own fucked up way I'd missed what he'd done to Lily, the slutty wench she becomes around him, what his masculine aggression does to her. I admitted I'd gone back to Leo and invited him to start fucking her again. I told her I suspected Sebastian found out about it and, unaware I'd invited Leo, saw Leo as disloyal and defiant and therefore had him removed.

"Sebastian was furious over the recording Leo made of you. Leo did that at one of Sebastian's parties. If word got out, Sebastian's impeccable reputation for discretion would be ruined."

"You think Sebastian had something to do with Leo's disappearance."

"I think Sebastian had *everything* to do with Leo's disappearance."

Lily looked at her drink like the milk had soured. She set the mug on the end table and pushed the cup away with a finger.

"I feel sick," she said.

"Yeah, me too. Leo warned me about Sebastian. Says the theater work is merely a launching pad for the other stuff he's into, some of it dark and dangerous."

Lily nodded. "I suspected that from Leo's pentagram tattoo and then the pentagram on the yacht. I didn't ask and he didn't tell. Leo vanishing makes it personal, though."

“We have proof of nothing. What if Leo panicked and ran, leaving everything behind? Sure, he made a sex tape of a guest, but that’s not enough to have a man killed. I’ll bet he did plenty of other things to anger Sebastian over the years. Maybe recording you was the last straw?”

Lily thought for a moment. “What about Mister Private Detective?”

“What about him? I’ve got nothing for that guy.”

“I feel for Leo’s wife. How awful. Can you imagine what she must be feeling? I go insane if you just disappeared one day. I’d never stop looking for you.”

She left the counter to lean into me and I hugged her with both arms.

“I hate that you did all that behind my back,” she said. “But I can’t get too angry with you.” She looked up at my face. “I certainly did plenty behind yours.”

Chapter 4

Lily and I were out to dinner when Sebastian sent the text. He had another party planned, dressy but not formal, in New Orleans, and would love for us to attend. He added he had something he wanted to hand us personally.

“That sounds ominous,” Lily said.

“Leo’s severed head, I’m guessing.”

Lily did not find me amusing.

The three weeks until the party passed quickly. Lily finished her role as Wanda in *Venus In Fur* and I hammered away at work. We flew out Thursday night for New Orleans.

From the airport, we shot down Freeway Ten to the French Quarter arriving at the Bourbon Orleans Hotel just before eight at night. Check-in was a breeze and soon we tipped the bellboy and threw the deadbolt. I was ready for food but Lily wanted to swim in the heated, black-bottom, saltwater pool.

“I am stressed and my muscles ache.”

She’d booked the room, which explained the giant four-poster bed, and I had no idea the hotel even had a heated pool.

“I brought no swim trunks,” I said.

“I’m fine going alone,” she said quickly. “Order some food. I won’t be long.”

Can one be curious without being suspicious? I'm not sure.

Since I became aware she'd fucked Leo all those weeks behind my back, I often wonder at moments like this if she has something else planned. Maybe she wanted to quietly float in hot water alone. She's human. I wouldn't say I distrust her now but I wonder more often. She's gained complexity in my eyes. Now that I know what she's capable of, I wonder what other surprises she has for me.

"All right," I said. "Be safe."

"The pool is in a courtyard," she said. "Hidden from the street. I'll be fine."

We kissed and hugged and she changed into a black one-piece and wrapped a hotel robe around her.

I grabbed the phone for room service.

She'd been gone only a few minutes when I looked out our window. Our room looked down on the courtyard and I watched until I saw her emerge. She took a lounge chair in the far corner and quickly stepped into the water. Two families and three single men enjoyed the pool along with her. I was still spying when my food arrived.

We'd picked this place because we were a mere two-minute walk from Saint Louis Cathedral, the site of Sebastian's event. Why he was holding it in one of the oldest Catholic churches in the United States, I had no idea, but the man had connections that fanned out in every direction. Lily and I had all day tomorrow and most of Saturday to ourselves. The event started at midnight Saturday night.

I feasted on gumbo and a cabernet while watching some news. After thirty minutes or so, I checked out the window again.

Lily sat on a step in the corner, water up to her tits, with a man on either side. The families were gone. The three of them had the pool to themselves. Normally I would have returned to my dinner but that's not our life now. Everything is a possible sexual encounter. Our recent history has shown us both that lust can rear its head at any moment. I stood watching until I decided the men were too shy or passive to try anything with such an attractive woman. Maybe they recognized her and were fans. I went back to eating. I finished my food and finished the news and checked again at the window but now the pool stood empty and alone.

I waited for Lily to open our front door.

I call it curiosity and not suspicion because if Lily wanted to fuck one of those guys and tell me about it later, she could. She's mine. We're married. Our vows, like almost everyone, included words like sickness and health, good times and bad. But that list is incomplete. The list should have things like even after you fuck someone else, or no matter how many other men have you, your husband is still the only man who has any legitimate claim. Not too romantic, I know. I understand why words like that are left off the list.

But that's the truth; no matter what either of us do with anyone else, we are truly connected only to each other. To put our agreement into acting parlance, every other person on Earth is a player on our stage. Lily and I are the leads.

An hour later her key beeped in the slot. The door opened and she stepped through and I instantly knew by the mischievous look in her eye.

"How do you know?" she asked, slipping her straps off her shoulders. Her big wet tits tumbled free.

I jerked a thumb at the window. "I spied."

I wanted to fuck her but she wanted to blow me. We stripped and I sat on the edge of the bed and dropped a pillow to the floor. She knelt and began a long, slow blowjob. I tried to fuck her but she stopped me again. Eventually I realized she was teasing me, seeing how long I could go before asking a question.

"What happened?" I said. "Where'd you go?"

She pulled her mouth off my dick head. "To Troy's room."

"Who's Troy?"

"A fine, strapping, young black man I met at the pool. Dominique whetted my appetite. Their smooth dark skin is so sexy, so enticing. I love the way it flows over the muscles beneath, revealing dips and bulges. It looks so healthy and vibrant. I told Troy he looked delicious and he said I should come back to his room and have a bite."

Now I understood why she wanted to blow me.

"You're tender."

"Yes...and messy."

Lily had cum in her right now. That drives me crazy every fucking time. My penis surged and she felt it and laughed. She had me and she knew it. I lay back on the bed and listened as she narrated her visit to Troy's room.

He'd fucked her hard but punctuated with surprising tenderness. She said she came when he fucked her from behind, his fat black cock stuffing her pussy, his hand around her throat and his hot breath in her ear.

"As soon as I started wailing he thrust faster and added his orgasm to mine. He'd been holding back and my cries told him to go ahead. I swear he came a gallon. I looked at him in disbelief and he explained he hadn't had sex in almost a year and not masturbated for almost a month because of his roommate situation."

She licked under my dick head and sucked repeatedly on the tip, scooping up little drops of precum that appeared.

"So that's why just a blowjob. You'd be swimming in him. Besides, don't you love it when another man is inside me and you're not?"

I groaned. I do. Her hand jerked my shaft as her mouth vacuumed and far too soon, I shot all over her tongue. She sucked hard and I lurched around like an idiot as she drained my balls. Finally, proud of herself, she left me lying on the bed and headed for the shower.

Chapter 5

Beautiful New Orleans.

We spent the day wandering the streets, heading first for Louis Armstrong park and Congo Square, and then looping around to Lalaurie Mansion before lunch at Coop's Place. After a long meal, we meandered along the muddy Mississippi down to Jackson Square before turning inland again for a walk through the French Quarter. Around dusk we found ourselves standing outside the Voodoo Museum with another couple, staring up at the sign.

The girl was sexy, with long brown hair and emerald eyes. The man, her husband I'd guess, was a little chubby. They debated a moment and then the husband said: "What do you think, April?"

She gave a nod and they entered together. I waited for the door to close.

"What do you think, Lily?"

Lily scrunched her face "Not really my thing."

"No, not really my thing either but when in Rome..."

She looked up at the sign again. "This *is* the heart of Voodoo country."

“Exactly,” I agreed. “Let’s at least look around.”

I held the door for her.

Inside, an emaciated black man easily a hundred years old sat behind the counter. He asked the couple ahead of us if he could help them and when they responded they were just looking around, he waved them away and told them to take all the time they needed. Lily and I wandered towards the back of the shop.

Every shelf was covered with dusty sculptures of human bodies, most twisted into painful positions. Old books, Voodoo paraphernalia, scrolls, and gemstones covered every square inch of shelving. Small human skeletons hung from black strings and death masks stared back at every turn. A multitude of dolls, male and female and sporting wildly exaggerated characteristics, stared back at me. One doll had a cock as long as his legs and formed a tripod which held a small mirror. Large glass jars filled with a pale-yellow liquid lined the walls and seemed to contain human organs. I saw a jar of dried chicken heads next to a jar of shriveled human hands that looked like they came from babies.

“Everything is about fucking or dying,” Lily breathed.

We moved into another room, smaller, each wall adorned with gorgeous paintings of sweaty male and female bodies, all bound and twisted into bizarre positions. Heads forced to the side or arms and legs folded back or turned uncomfortably. Despite what was being done to them, an examination of the faces showed every victim in the throes of ecstasy.

“They seem to like it,” I joked.

“Who wouldn’t?” Lily teased. “Every male is hung like a horse.”

The couple from earlier moved through the room on their way toward the back wall. I noted a dark doorway and black wooden stairs that led down. I raised a questioning eyebrow to Lily.

“Yeah. No.”

“I agree. Should we buy a souvenir?”

“That’s a good idea. I already know what I want.”

Lily took my hand and steered us back to the first room. She found a small marble sculpture of Michelangelo’s David on a bottom shelf, but liberties had been taken with his genitalia, so that they now reached halfway to his knees.

“I’m pretty sure that’s not a factual representation of the artist’s vision,” I said.

“No shit. I want it for our bathroom counter. Start each day with some class.”

“Elegant.”

“Humorous,” she corrected.

At the register, I asked the man how long he’d lived in New Orleans.

“All of my lives,” he answered and for a second I thought about asking him to clarify but Lily discretely tugged my sleeve.

“Beautiful city,” I said. “Thank you.”

“Thank you,” he rattled.

We left him and the other couple and continued our walk down the street, randomly arriving at a place called Café Lafitte in Exile. A sign in the window proclaimed it was the longest operating gay bar in the United States.

“Food?” Lily asked.

“Perfect.”

The interior was brass and heavy dark wood and glass. Off the main entrance steps led down to a bar. A friendly man greeted us with a question about food or liquor and when we told him food, he led us to a table.

“Your waiter, David, will be with you shortly,” he smiled.

I scanned the menu.

“Wow,” Lily said. “Like, wow.”

I looked up. She was staring at a waiter standing by the bar.

“You like him?”

“Drop. Dead. Gorgeous.”

He approached our table and I had fun watching Lily trying to remain cool. We introduced ourselves and he chatted about life in New Orleans and then we got around to the menu. He made recommendations, we made choices, and he left to put our orders in.

“In a heartbeat,” Lily said.

“I didn’t ask.”

“In a *heartbeat* .”

The food was delicious and our waiter shared his duties with five other tables. Lily gawked unabashedly. She was staring at him when our couple from the museum came through the front door.

“Weird,” I said. “They picked the same restaurant too. What are the odds?”

David visited their table and spent time talking with them, and then headed for the kitchen with their orders.

“The wife likes him,” Lily said. “Watch her when he comes back. They’re a shy couple, at least not as adventurous as us, but the wife wants him badly.”

I shifted my chair to better see. Lily was right. As time passed we saw the husband warm up and eventually help his wife flirt with David.

We finished our meal and opted for dessert. We had no place to be. The other couple left.

“She’s going to fuck him,” Lily said. “I saw it on her face. The husband invited David back to their hotel and she’s going to fuck him but they have no idea what they’re doing. They’re like us months ago. Holy shit, that’s hot.”

I chuckled.

We finished our meal, tipped David well, and headed back to the Bourbon Hotel for a nap. I set the alarm on my phone. Hours later we woke and got ready. I brewed some coffee in the room and we both took hot showers.

“What do you think this party is all about?” Lily asked.

“No idea. With Sebastian involved it could seriously be anything.”

“Fascinating guy, isn’t he?”

“Yeah. Mostly gay, mostly genius, mostly trustworthy, slightly dangerous, slightly macabre, slightly odd; he’s a little bit of everything and a lot of some things.”

“That’s a great way to put it.”

“Thank you.”

Lily flipped a pure white dress over her head and shimmied into the straps. I looked closer and saw tiny eyelets stitched into the fabric. Up close, you saw bare skin. Step back even a few feet, she wore a white dress with an intricate pattern.

“That’s lovely,” I said.

“Thank you. Discretely sexy. Would you mind not wearing that blue sports coat and jeans? I brought along black dress slacks with matching jacket and charcoal dress shirt for you.”

I quickly changed, adding a gray and purple tie that matched the shirt.

“Lyft?” I asked.

“I’m wearing flats and it’s two blocks. If you don’t mind, I’d like to walk.”

I checked the clock; eleven-forty-five. “Sure. We’ll make it.”

We did.

The neighborhoods between our hotel and the cathedral were lively, narrow streets packed with people and music. As soon as we turned onto Chartres street, all that changed. Jackson Square, so full of life just hours ago, may as well have been a graveyard. The Louisiana State Museum was as quiet as a morgue. I expected a crowd outside the church but nothing. The building was dark.

“Did I get the instructions wrong?” Lily asked. She opened her phone, reading, checking street signs, reading, checking building number, reading, checking time.

“Nope,” she announced.

“I’ll knock and see if they know what’s going on.”

“The place looks deserted,” she warned.

The front of the building was protected by a short iron fence with gates for three evenly spaced doors. The two side gates were closed so I moved to the middle door and tapped lightly with a knuckle. I noticed twin etching around the door handles looked like faint pentagrams. Metal scraped and the door opened a crack. Orange light shimmered behind the thousand-year-old man that confronted me.

“We’re here to meet Sebastian?” I said.

The zombie stepped back six inches and opened the door a like amount. I shrugged at Lily and waved her through, following close behind. The man wore a heavy black robe, tied at the waist with gold sash. He slammed a heavy iron bar to seal the door behind us and Lily jumped.

Inside was a narrow hallway with hundreds of candles staggered all along the walls. We waited for our host and he led us at a glacial pace to the far door. That opened onto the main floor; pews to the left and right. Arched, vaulted, painted ceiling, with hundreds more candles lining the walls.

Opulence is too shallow a word for this huge room. The detail snatched breath. Even with mere candlelight the lavish extravagance was obvious. Colorful, ornate paintings and complex mosaics crawled across every inch. Fluted pillars supported open balconies. Miniscule carvings

detailed every pew. The main altar sat back under a gazebo like covering, as decorative as all the rest. Before it was an open area of carpet and marble.

“What a beautiful church,” I said, meaning it.

“Basilica,” Zombie grumbled, annoyed.

I did not ask the difference. He led us down the main path towards the altar and as we drew closer we saw Latin words carved in the stonework above.

“What’s ‘ecce panis angelorum’?” Lily asked.

“A command to cannibalize,” the old man chuckled.

My wife and I exchanged baffled looks.

There was more writing on the wall, higher than the first.

“What’s ‘ego sum via et veritas et vita’?” Lily asked.

The walking cadaver stopped and turned, glaring at us.

“The Great Lie,” he croaked.

Lily made a face like she was done asking him questions.

The old man reached the steps up to the altar and took each with trembling legs. When he reached the open area, he stopped and pointed at the floor.

“Tread lightly or disturb the dead.” He chuckled again, delighted with his own sly joke. Lily looked at me.

“Are bodies buried there?”

“Seems so,” I said.

We followed the man but stepped over and around the area he’d indicated. He waved a bony hand at various nearby structures. “No matter children, bodies interred all around you.”

Lily moved closer to my side.

“Officially sealed in the walls,” he added. “Secretly hidden in the columns.”

Okay, now he was just trying to creep us out.

When we reached the altar, he braced a palm and pushed hard. On well-oiled springs the massive marble block swung aside, pivoting around an off-center point. Spiral stairs led straight down into darkness.

“Oh, Hell no,” Lily whispered.

“We go down?” I asked.

He showed four teeth in a grin. “You go down.”

I saw in his eyes he was hoping I’d start asking questions. He’d love to ignore them all and cause our fright to grow. I took Lily’s hand and

headed down the steep decline, bracing my free hand against the circular wall. She followed tightly behind me.

We'd made several turns, the dim candlelight above fading quickly, when we heard the altar swing in place over us and all light go out.

"What the fuck, Luke?" Lily whimpered. "This is nuts. I'm scared."

Ahead made more sense than back so I continued in the blackness, feeling each step with my toes first. After many more turns, I saw a faint flickering red glow.

We stepped out into an open area several stories below street level. The air was cold and wet from the seeping Mississippi and the walls were in terrible shape. Piles of crumbling plaster lay everywhere. Barely legible frescos adorned the walls, each depicting some horrible torture done to a bound human; inverted crucifixions and bodies broken on the rack, men and women burned at the stake or buried alive.

A woman approached wearing a hooded black robe and carrying a candelabra lit with skinny red candles. She led us to a small room beyond an archway. Dozens of wicker baskets lined the walls, stuffed with shoes. She pointed to half a dozen empties.

"Remove your shoes and place them in a basket."

"Really? Barefoot?" Lily asked.

"Yes."

"Kind of chilly down here," my wife said. "Dirty floors."

The woman gave her a face of stone.

"All right, we'll do it," Lily said. Then, to me: "So much for 'Dressy, not formal.' Thanks, Sebastian."

The woman handed us small, black-lace masks. "Discretion is important."

"Of course," I said.

"Speak little. Do not remove the masks for any reason."

Lily and I slipped the masks over our head and then helped each other adjust the fabric until they sat comfortably. They worked surprisingly well in the low light. When the woman told us to follow her, we did.

We were led down a long twisting hallway and into a large round room with domed ceiling. The rock under our feet was cold, damp, and gritty. Life-sized sculptures lined the room and I recognized several from the Voodoo museum earlier. The deterioration of the walls and ceiling alarmed me. Large flakes of paint and stucco had fallen, some recently,

exposing the raw limestone beneath. The moisture in the air told me the Mighty Mississippi was only a few feet behind that wall. I thought I heard the waters rushing by. I remembered every World War Two submarine movie I'd ever seen, expecting Lily and I would drown when the walls gave way and our chamber flooded.

Farther out in the room, well-dressed figures, masked like us, formed a circle around a large block of marble about four feet high. The top eight inches had been carved as the lid and sides of a coffin. Next to the block stood a podium. Red wax candles as large as my leg randomly filled the space between observers and the coffin and podium. Small stone steps led up the marble block.

The woman directed us to an opening in the ring of people and walked us to our position. She left without a word.

Lily and I stood for a time and watched others arrive like we had. Slowly, the circle of people grew deeper. Because I wonder about such things I passed the time counting people.

"There are sixty-six of us," I whispered to Lily.

"So?"

"Just saying."

"Nerd."

The ceiling was too dark to see much detail but I saw hints of architecture that made me think we were in a much smaller version of the basilica upstairs.

Somewhere distant, a gong sounded.

From a dark, unseen tunnel, I saw a procession of six candelabra-carrying hooded black-robos enter the room. Behind them came a woman riding a palanquin carried by six naked muscular men in front and six in back. Behind them came another six black-robed candle bearers.

The woman wore a white lace corset which left her breasts exposed and a matching lace veil which hung almost to the floor. White lace gloves reached to her elbows. Long blonde hair piled around her shoulders. Because she was seated I couldn't be sure but she seemed to be without panties.

The candle bearers spread out around the large block and the muscle men first set the palanquin on the floor and then hurried to lay on their bellies. The girl stepped out and walked across their backs to the marble

coffin. She wore no panties, in fact, and her bald pussy was obvious even in the dim light.

“Is, is this a wedding?” Lily whispered.

Someone nearby hissed at us.

I surveyed the scene and concluded Lily was right. How did I miss that?

The bride reached the stone coffin and climbed the small steps to stand upon it, looking down on all of us.

“She looks familiar,” I muttered.

Lily’s gaze jumped to her face, trying to see through the obscuring veil.

From the same tunnel the wedding procession had emerged, a tall old man, dressed in standard cassock with white square at the throat, appeared and took his place behind the podium.

Somewhere, slow, deep drums began a beat.

“Who surrenders his bride?” the old vicar boomed.

A small, uncertain voice echoed from the passageway. “I do.”

A man exited the tunnel and Lily gasped. Her eyes flew to the veiled woman.

“Luke,” she rasped. “That’s Violet up there. That man’s her husband, Alex. They’ve been married for—“

“Silence!” a nearby voice hissed again. “Or be removed.”

I remembered Violet. Ages ago I saw her sucking Jimmy’s cock in a backroom at the Reynolds theater. She was a pretty blonde co-star that somehow never got lead roles. Last I’d heard, she’d mostly withdrawn from stage to concentrate on movies roles.

She had long thin legs, shapely, and a bubble butt. The lace corset thrust her bare tits, a little too big for her frame, up and out. They looked delicious. The veil somewhat hid her face but now that I knew it was her I recognized her.

She looked terrified and she looked drugged. I remembered Lily on Jay’s yacht, high as a kite and fucking a demonic appendage attached to the floor. These people liked to drug their victims.

The priest summoned Alex and had him kneel before the podium.

“Alexander, do you surrender her womb for another’s use?”

“I do,” he squeaked.

The priest gestured to a candle-bearer at the front of the crowd. The individual placed their candelabra on the floor and took a half step forward.

Alex was trying to be strong but this was killing him.

I love watching Lily fuck, but this seemed to be something altogether different. Were Alex and Violet adding another man to their marriage? Worse, another *husband*?

Fuck that. Lily is *mine*. My mind flipped.

“Do you surrender her body to another’s touch?”

“I do.”

Alex’s face was pure anguish. This was *not* his idea. Or, if it was, he was having some serious second-thoughts about it now.

“Do you surrender your sole position?”

“I do,” he whined.

“Mister Reiner, please step forward.”

The black-robe from earlier untied his sash and shrugged the robe from his shoulders. He was naked beneath and he was a strong man, with muscular shoulders and thick arms. Curly black hair topped his head and a cocky grin stretched his lips. His veiny dick was already half-erect. I gazed at his large testicles because I knew at that moment Alex was doing exactly the same thing.

“Reiner,” the priest continued. “You chose this woman. Will you mount her?”

“I will.”

Yeah, I knew where this was headed.

Violet looked at her husband anxiously, but all her worry was for him with none left over for herself.

“Bride, offer your slit.”

Violet knelt until she was on all fours and then lowered her head to the marble coffin, leaving her ass high in the air. Her face was now only a few feet from her husband’s, her lovely veil cascading to the vault floor. The muscular man climbed the steps, lightly stroking his hefty cock, growing stiffer by the second. He moved until he stood behind Violet.

“Holy shit,” Lily breathed. “This is intense.”

I glanced at Alex again. No, this was pure torture. He was a slight man with an earnest face and caring eyes. In a wrestling match, Reiner could fold Alex in half. I met Alex once, backstage after a performance. He brought me a coffee and we talked about the history of flight while we

waited for our lovely wives. He'd been so proud of Violet then, bragging about her successes and how much they loved each other.

Reiner, the bastard, knelt and held Violet in place by her hips. His big cock now curled up from his pelvis, eager for carnage.

Alex reached a tentative hand out to land atop his wife's. They laced fingers.

Violet's expression was worry smothered by anticipation. Her body responded to Reiner behind her. I was sure she was soaked. Her eyes showed she felt some remorse but her body burned with wicked intent. She longed for that encroaching cock to pierce and sink deep.

"I love you," Alex murmured.

"I love—"

She never finished. That bastard Reiner let her speak the first words and then pushed his stiff inches into her body. Her mouth flew open and her toes curled and a silent scream poured from her throat. She squeezed Alex's fingers and slowly lifted her head from the marble. Reiner shoved her head back down and flexed his muscular ass, driving his fleshy railroad spike balls-deep. Violet gasped intensely and Alex looked like someone had killed his kitten.

"Keep her hand in yours," Reiner told Alex. "I want you to feel this too."

The brute began fucking Violet's pussy hard, driving her exposed breasts into twirling circles. We all heard the sloshing wetness of her arousal.

Reiner moved his body farther over her and cupped a bouncing tit. His hips pounded the pretty woman beneath him, sending shock waves through her body and down her arm to her hand. Alex held on tightly as another man vigorously claimed his gorgeous wife

I checked on Lily. My wife watched with rapt attention. Her big eyes wandered Reiner's strong body and I wondered if she wanted Reiner for herself.

The attending crowd pressed closer. Black-robos, members of the wedding party I now realized, began slipping out of their gowns and moving into a tight circle around the altar. Hands emerged from the crowd, pawing at the new bride. Alex found himself surrounded by others mauling his wife.

Reiner held nothing back. A hurried orgasm was his selfish goal but Violet climaxed first. Alex looked like a blade of ice had pierced his heart when Violet's sweet voice rose in pleasure. Disbelief made his face sag. Reiner's cock had easily and quickly ripped an orgasm from his beloved.

Whatever despair the man felt faded before the utter hopelessness of Reiner roaring with ultimate satisfaction. Alex watched helplessly as the muscular beast inseminated Violet only inches away. I knew his pain, flashing back to my first time.

Reiner gasped and moaned as his flood left him and he pushed out every drop.

When his balls were empty, he stood, his mostly deflated cock dribbling sperm and pussy juice.

"Turn her over," he told the crowd. "I share my new bride with all."

Alex's spirit turned to dust. As Violet's true fate became apparent, her glassy-eyed husband surveyed the seething crowd. Reiner had merely been the first.

Hands moved quickly and Violet was flipped onto her back, assisting her army of new lovers as best she could. She glowed with lust. Whatever drug they'd given her had sunk claws deep. When the first anonymous penis was shoved at her face, she willingly opened her mouth and closed tight lips around the drooling head.

Reiner descended the steps, granting the place to another. An old black man moved through the crowd and Violet's pussy was pulled to the edge of the coffin.

I recognized the man from behind the counter at the Voodoo museum we visited earlier. Lily recognized him too and her eyes snapped up to mine.

"That's..." Her voice trailed off as she realized I recognized him too.

A bouquet of cocks, every size and colors, waved in Violet's face. She sucked each without hesitation. Hands roamed her soft skin, played with her tits. Mouths fell on her nipples and suckled her full breasts. Someone worked a finger up her ass from below. The old black man shouted with passion as his load exploded from his cock inside this hot new bride. Another man shot ropes of creamy sperm across her face.

Lily and I gazed at each other, disbelieving. Aroused, disgusted, surprised; all we could do was shake our heads. Violet disappeared under a

wave of hungry males. Alex remained by her side as the crowd emptied their balls all over, around, and in her.

Lily leaned closer to me and I put an arm around her shoulders.

Not all the men present joined in but most did. I glanced around the crowd and saw some waiting their turn while others held back and watched. I'd made almost a complete circuit of the room when I saw a familiar face. The masks were good but not that good. No way would I miss Sebastian leaning against a deteriorating wall, engaged in casual conversation. I nudged Lily's elbow with my own.

"Be cool but there's Sebastian across the room, under the balcony."

Lily was smooth. "Oh, fuck," she said, after a moment.

"What's wrong?"

"The man he's talking to? That's Jay, from the yacht."

My blood turned cold.

Violet's cries of a second orgasm brought me back; her back arched off the carved marble, her tits thrust towards the ceiling, her nipples hard and swollen. In the red candlelight, she was one of the most erotic sights I'd ever seen, made more so because I knew her. One look at Lily's face told me Lily felt the same.

We stepped back into the throng but kept our eyes on the carnal spectacle before us. Jay finished his conversation and exited using a tunnel. Lily and I watched one man after the next use Violet for his own pleasure and then erupt, filling her with seed. Cum ran from her messy cunt to the coffin beneath her ass.

"It's so raw, so animal," Lily exhaled. "I'm disgusted, sickened by it, but my body craves it. I envy her, Luke."

I tightened my arm around her shoulder, dispelling any thought I may allow her to join Violet. Not that Lily was thinking such a thing, but I wanted her to know my feelings. She leaned into me and wrapped her arms around my waist, thankful for my reassuring presence.

We watched a long time, until the last man fucking Violet's sloppy hole ejaculated and crawled off her. We then watched as a team of three black-robed women approached the marble block, one carrying a small, hand-held kit. They worked together on the swooning Violet, tapping a small, inverted pentagram tattoo just above her pussy. They used a crude needle, ink, and wooden mallet. Lily and I exchanged a knowing look; we'd

seen pentagrams before. After Violet, the three women moved to Alex and marked him in the same way.

Reiner held back until every man and woman that wanted Violet had enjoyed her.

“Return to your hotel room,” Reiner told Alex. “I’ll send her to you Sunday.”

Reiner helped Violet stand and then, holding her hand, led her away down the tunnel. A forlorn Alex dragged himself to his feet and headed for the shoe room.

Movement close drew my eye and I turned to see Sebastian.

“Glad you could make it,” he said, politely.

“What the fuck, Sebastian?” Lily blurted.

“No names, Love.”

“Oh. Sorry. What just happened? What did we just watch?”

Sebastian turned to watch Reiner and Violet vanish through the tunnel mouth. He smoothed his black goatee. “Our mutual friend now has two husbands. Two husbands and all the resources and connections associated with each.”

I furrowed my brow wondering what that meant. Lily was way ahead of me.

“She married to advance her career?”

“That’s one reason, yes.”

“Wow.”

Sebastian reached into his coat pocket and withdrew a small black cassette tape cartridge. He handed it to me.

“What’s this?” I asked.

“That is the final recording of a certain woman enjoying herself at one of my parties. All other copies and originals have been deleted or destroyed.”

Holy shit. Leo had given this to a friend. That Sebastian had it meant Leo was almost certainly dead.

“Thank you,” I said, trying to sound cool. “And what of the man that made them?”

Sebastian gave me a hard stare. The lace mask made him look like a super villain capable of reading minds. He skipped over my question like I’d never asked it.

“Did you enjoy the ceremony?” He made a small wave towards the coffin.

“Yes,” Lily said, a little too fast in my opinion.

“Mind blowing,” I admitted, taking the tape from his hand. “But more pentagrams? I noticed some hidden on the front doors of the cathedral too.”

“They do set a mood,” he said, quoting me from a while ago.

I laughed. “The devil never actually appears at one of your parties... right?”

“No, don’t be foolish. There is no devil.”

I raised an eyebrow. “Then why invoke him? Why these Satanic overtones to everything you do?”

“All right.” He glanced around to make sure we were out of ear-shot. “You’re an intelligent and curious man so I’ll indulge you. The Devil never appears but what *does* appear is a dividing line between my many invited guests. I quickly learn those willing to embrace a darker side. I can sort a room in minutes, knowing who is comfortable ignoring social restrictions and by how much, and who is not.”

“I won’t ask why that information is valuable to you.”

“I wouldn’t answer, not with specifics.”

“Remind me never to cross you.”

“Okay; never cross me. I can field an army of the morally flexible in a day.”

I laughed again. “Morally flexible. I like that.”

“I’m glad I amuse you. Sadly, now I must leave. I’m meeting friends soon and I need to prepare.”

Lily let go of my arm and gave Sebastian a hug, which he returned

Chapter 6

“That was crazy,” Lily said.

We were back on the streets and looking for a place to eat. For some reason the show left us both ravenous. We’d found our shoes and another black-robe had shown us out through a tunnel hidden behind a pillar. The passageways under the old church were twisting and numerous and falling to ruin.

“What a fucking night,” I agreed.

We had nervous energy and plenty of it. We walked fast, breathing hard, feet pounding the sidewalks. We made random turns, allowing chance to guide our feet, and turned one last corner to discover ourselves facing Café Lafitte in Exile, again.

I showed Lily my palms. "Fine with me. Good food."

She took my hands and gazed into my eyes. "Did you bring us here?"

"What? No. You saw; we made arbitrary turns at every intersection. Why would you ask that?"

She looked at the restaurant and back at me. "I want him."

Oh.

"Honey," I said, cautiously. "We were here hours ago. He's probably gone home. The restaurant side is closed. Only the bar is still open."

"I'm sure you're right," she said, still holding my hands. "I'm just saying in case."

"I understand. I'm worked up by what we just saw too. Why don't we forget about this place, go back to our room, order room service and fuck until morning?"

Her eyes were pleading. "I don't want to hurt you and try to hear it in the spirit I mean it, but after what we just saw, I need something far dirtier than sex with my husband."

OH.

My eyes betrayed me so she kept talking.

"Luke, I love you with all my heart, but look where we are. How did we end up here? That's too crazy to be coincidence. Some force guided us here. I feel like this means something."

Her desire for him and not me stung, I'll admit that.

"What happens to me?"

"You watch me, Honey. I feel like being a complete slut in front of my loving husband. Unless that would weird him out. Then you'll need to hang out at a bar or something for an hour or two."

"First we need to see if he's even here."

She looped her arm through mine and crossed the street.

He was there. We entered and found seats at the bar and I ordered drinks as Lily scanned the place. I felt her tense next to me and a small gasp escape.

"In the corner," she said. "Under the big screen."

He sat nursing a beer and watching a bluegrass band perform at a festival.

“What now?” I asked.

The bartender dropped two napkins and our drinks before walking away.

“Now I go tell him.”

Lily kissed me, sipped her martini, slid out of her barstool, and aimed for the corner and David’s table. I watched him closely. He was the tall, dark, and handsome type; a little thin, short black hair and big blue eyes, fast and easy smile. I worried he’d not remember Lily and hurt her feelings but I’m an idiot; of course he remembered Lily.

I sipped my Sazerac and watched them talk. I heard nothing but I didn’t need to. Lily did most the talking anyway. She inched closer to him and he glanced at me a couple times but whatever she sold, he bought.

She eased between his knees and kissed him. I felt my face turn red and was thankful for the dark bar. The place was only moderately busy but I knew at least a few people watched that happen and knew. She’s a pretty girl and turns heads. Plenty saw her walk in with me. What was happening now was obvious.

They kissed again and she pressed her tits against his body. He stroked her long hair. She took his hand and led him back to me.

I shook his hand.

“I’ve a room around the corner,” he offered, getting to it. “You’re both welcome.”

“Lead the way,” I said, trying to sound calm.

Out on the sidewalk Lily walked with him two paces ahead of me. I was slightly annoyed but already my balls ached. I loved how badly she wanted him but at the same time her runaway desire made me jealous. She wasn’t just horny and craving dick; she was craving *his* dick.

We headed down Bourbon Street and hung a left on Saint Philips and true to his word he led us to an iron gate that opened into a courtyard and off that a small apartment with a green door. He turned the knob and Lily followed him through and I followed her.

The place was decorated in drab early American college student; cinderblock shelves and a couch with no legs and a French flag pinned to a dingy wall. Lily did not care. They were undressing each other as fast as

they could. My wife kept staring at his face, mesmerized by how beautiful he was.

“Can you act?” she said. “You should move to Hollywood. You’d make a ton of money making movies. Women would pay just to look at you.”

He didn’t answer. Lily liked his looks but he felt the same about her. They fumbled with zippers and buttons and then her dress sailed over her head. I expected she’d try to blow him but she had no time for that. She needed him in her. He was stiff when his pants came down and she backed away pulling him forward until the couch hit her behind the knees. David landed on top and she quickly reached between his legs while they kissed. All the air left her lungs. I knew he’d slid home. Just like that, my wife had a stranger buried in her pussy.

Some light came through the drapes and some through the kitchen window but there wasn’t a lot to see. He still wore his undershirt and his ass rose and fell hard and fast. Despite the circumstances, I felt myself stiffen. Just the recognizable sounds of Lily’s pleasure were enough to set my heart racing. Her ankles locked behind his ass and my wife slapped her hands on his butt, pulling him deeper every thrust. He was moaning loudly but so was she.

I sat on the arm of a nearby chair, feeling out of place and unnecessary but excited anyway. I took my penis out to stroke. I saw them kissing wildly in the low light. As always, I grew more excited as she did, because her passion feeds my passion.

Way too soon, her fingers were clawing his ass as she came. He thoughtfully hammered away, driving her even higher.

When he felt his climax approach he asked where she wanted it. For answer she just held his handsome face with both hands and dug her heels into his ass. He scooped his hands under her butt to hold her in place and fucked her hole, driving deep when his sperm began squirting. Lily was thrilled to take it and said so loudly, again and again.

I didn’t quite get there. They burned so hot for each other and fucked so hard and fast, I was too bust watching every detail and not paying enough attention to my own excitement. Before I could cum, they were finished and nothing more than a pile of arms and legs breathing heavy on the couch. I tucked my penis away.

“There’s...beer...in the...fridge,” he said, between gulps of air.

Happy for something to do, I returned with three.

They'd disentangled a bit and now leaned against the back cushions. Lily was between his legs but resting on an elbow. I handed the beers over and suddenly none of us knew what to say. We shared a moment of intense awkward silence and then we all laughed together.

"I am having the craziest night ever," David admitted.

Lily's eyes got big. "So are we and I bet we have you beat."

"Don't be too sure. I spent time with another couple earlier. They picked me up at the restaurant too."

"We watched a girl get gang-banged by more than twenty men," Lily announced

David choked on his beer. "You win. Jesus."

I raised a beer. "To crazy nights."

They joined me and we all took a drink.

We gradually relaxed and soon the conversation moved smoothly.

"Did you fuck that green-eyed woman?" Lily asked, out of the blue.

David knew who she meant and did not shy away. "You mean April? No. I wanted to. I went back to their hotel with them but left with only a blowjob. How do you know Keith and April?"

"We don't," she said, coyly. "I saw her flirting with you and knew she'd try something. I thought she'd fuck you. She's hot."

"She is. They're headed to Florida for a high school reunion. Maybe I'll catch her on the way back."

We talked a while longer but I was tired and Lily was exhausted. When I felt the opportunity presented itself, I suggested we head back to the hotel. They made out for a minute and then Lily dressed while we watched her do it. She's such a gorgeous and sexy woman.

David gave Lily his number in case we ever visit New Orleans again and we left his place. Lily clung to my arm as we walked down the quiet city street. She didn't thank me but I knew that's what she felt.

I got our bearings at the first intersection and soon we stepped into our hotel room, stripped, and dropped into bed like stones.

Lily snuggled up to my chest and I hooked my arm around her.

"Violet," she said, after a moment. "I never saw that coming."

"Me either."

Another moment of silence and she asked if I'd cum watching her and David.

“No. Close, but no. It was over too fast.”

Her hand closed around me under the covers. “Maybe I can help,” she said.

“I’d love that,” I said. Lily started playing with my penis. I continued: “Violet and Alex got matching upside-down pentagram tattoos, just like the one Leo has.”

“I was wondering about that. Did Gloria experience the same thing Violet did?”

“I think so. But with that group of rich crazies, who knows?” I asked.

“I bet that’s why Leo was so insubordinate all the time. I wonder if it was consensual or they used it to punish him?”

“That’s an interesting thought.”

Lily shivered. Her hand started sliding up and down my dick.

“Can you imagine yourself in Violet’s place?” I asked.

She shivered again. After a long pause: “Yes.”

I held my breath.

“Not the two-husbands part but the crowd of men part. She was at the bottom of a well of cocks. All those hands and mouths all over her. Men continuously fucking her mouth and pussy, replaced by other men as soon as they ejaculated. God, it was so intense. There was semen everywhere; on her feet and stomach, all over her veil and face and back. She was surrounded by throbbing erections and lusty men. Yet for all the guys that came on her there was still much more *inside* her. The two husbands idea is sketchy but the crowd of men fucking you is hot. I love how men are animals.”

I exhaled. Whew.

“Alex looked tortured,” she continued. “Violet felt his pain but couldn’t help herself, and I know it wasn’t just the drugs. I know her.”

Lily lifted her face to mine.

“How would you feel with twenty or thirty women all over you?”

I smiled. “That sounds awful.”

“Smart ass.”

We kissed. I knew she was wiped out but I wanted to cum.

“Even that ancient black man from the museum was there,” she said. “He looked like someone unwrapped a mummy. Violet saw him between her legs and looked down at his hard, black cock and her eyes got huge. I

know she's never been with a black guy. Can you imagine getting your first like that?"

"I wonder what happens now? What exactly does two-husbands mean? Can Reiner fuck her whenever he wants? Will Violet live with Reiner part time?"

Lily's eyes got big.

"God! That's intense," she breathed. "Are Violet and Reiner on some kind of honeymoon right now? Is Alex watching or did they leave him behind? What emotional agony." Her hand started again on my dick.

I saw her imagination running wild. "What would you do, Baby?"

"I'd never give you up like that," I said.

"But what if you had to?"

"I wouldn't."

"But what if you *had* to?"

I forced myself to consider it.

"It would be awful, Baby. I'd hate it. It would tear me up inside."

"Reiner would fuck me like I was his because I *would* be his."

"It would drive me insane. You may wander off, sometimes far, but I always know a thread connects us no matter what. I'm different from every other guy because at the heart of things, you're mine alone."

"But for Alex that's no longer true," she said.

"No."

"I bet his dick is hard as nails."

That comment surprised me. "Why would you say that?"

"Well, I know how much you love taking me back when I've been bad. This seems like the supreme threat. This is even worse than some man getting me pregnant, if you think about it. This attacks the foundation of *everything*. It's the ultimate line in the sand. I just thought, being a man, his dick would get hard, ready for the fight."

"You might be on to something. What would *you* do, Lily?"

She stopped stroking and gave me a wicked grin. "I'd love it."

"Why?"

"Because I'm the prize. I'm what the fighting's all about. I bet all those ships on the horizon made Helen of Troy wet. I'm a feminist but we love being fought over."

"That's why you'd like to be on that altar."

She giggled.

“But I’d never do it, Baby. I’m yours alone. I might fuck twenty guys some night but I’d still be your and only yours.”

She gave my penis another squeeze. “Can we save him for later? I’m so sleepy I’m about to pass out.”

“Sure, Honey.”

We were both asleep in moments.

For breakfast the next morning we left the hotel and walked along the Mississippi. We found a little hole-in-the-wall pancake house and feasted. Halfway through Lily nudged me under the table and gestured with an elbow. Four tables over the couple from the museum scarfed down waffles and pancakes just like we did. When I turned to Lily she beamed with pride.

“Ha,” she said around a mouthful of pancake and maple syrup. “I fucked him and she didn’t.”

Chapter 7

“That might be the single most boring costume you’ve ever worn,” I said.

Lily threw a wadded tissue at me. “Get out. It’s not that kind of show.”

I retrieved the missile and dropped it in the bathroom trash.

After our return from Louisiana, Lily signed a contract for *Come From Away*, a play about all the passengers in airplanes headed to New York but redirected to the town of Gander, Newfoundland, on September eleventh, two thousand one. Lily’s modest country-girl costume hid everything that had so far made her semi-famous. The play also called for her to sing on occasion and that was a big part of why she accepted the role. She was ready for new challenges.

The play was doing well, as was work for me. We’d fallen into a predictable routine, enjoying success but wondering, of late, what was next.

A few weeks after we got home we were reading in the den when Lily asked me how I felt about what happened to Leo. I mentioned, again, we had no proof of what happened to Leo and she just gave me this look that said knock off the bullshit.

“Okay. I feel terrible. I had my doubts but those evaporated when Sebastian handed me that tape. I’m a little frightened of Sebastian and his

devil-worshipping crowd, and I think Jay and his super-rich friends are parasites on humanity.”

“Voodooist,” she’d said. “Not devil-worshippers.”

“Sebastian sure makes it look that way.”

“Theater.”

“Why do you suddenly know about Voodooists?”

“I read up on them after we got home.”

A tiny alarm bell had pinged in the back of my head but I’d ignored it.

“How do *you* feel about Leo?” I’d asked.

“Sad. I miss him, and I feel for his wife. That detective is probably still looking.”

“That detective better steer clear of Sebastian and his cronies.”

Now, months later, Lily’s run at *Come From Away* was drawing to a close. We sat at breakfast, eating and reading. Tonight would be her final performance and she had nothing new lined up. I turned the page on my Kindle copy of the *Washington Post* and began reading the entertainment news.

Ten minutes later I said one word, loud and clear: “Huh.”

“What?”

I expanded the article which had so captured my attention and turned the device towards Lily. She read the headline: *Violet Sanders lands co-star role opposite Tom Cruise in remake of The Mummy*.

“Get the fuck out of Dodge!” she exclaimed.

“Want to bet Reiner produces movies?”

She looked at me and then down at the article. Her eyes moved across the page.

“They start filming in Oxford in April.” She turned to a second page and ran a quick search. “Reiner is listed as an executive producer.” She continued reading until she finished.

“Violet’s stock just soared,” she said, looking up. “Co-star with Cruise? Jesus. I can only imagine how much she got paid for this film. She probably just made for one film what I made over the last four years in theater.”

“But you love theater.”

Her shoulders sagged. “It’s true. I do.”

The conversation died there and Lily returned my Kindle, but that was the moment everything shifted. She said she loved acting and I know that was the truth, but over the next several months I saw Lily's fire for acting dim. She went weeks between gigs or even looking for them. When offers arrived she always had a complaint or said she wasn't interested.

Many weeks later, over dinner, she said she might try her hand at film.

"I support you, Baby. Do you know anyone in the industry?"

"No, but I'll ask around. I know a lot of people now. It might be fun to go to auditions again too."

"I'm sure you'll attack it like you do everything."

I was right, but film proved far more difficult. Lily found herself surrounded by crowds of stunning women, all willing to do whatever it took to win the fame and fortune of a Hollywood life. Lily arranged daily readings, sometimes twice daily, but was never selected for call back. She hammered away for weeks, determined to make something happen, but nothing did.

She was humbled.

She never cried; she'd had far too much success at stage for that little tantrum, but she did grow depressed. When she took a play just to stay busy, she said it felt like a huge step backward. I encouraged her to keep trying.

"Some people spend their entire lives trying to get a break. You only lose when you quit," I said.

She stuck with it.

In some ways, I envied her. My job was a predictable endeavor. My columns added up. My days held no surprises. I experienced no lows but neither any highs. Not that I would ever try the life she enjoyed. I am simply not wired for it, but I did miss occasional surprises.

She stuck with it some more.

Poor thing. All those phone calls, all those emails, all those auditions, all those meetings; nothing.

I was washing my car in the driveway on Saturday morning when I thought of it and the fact it took me this long told how shaken I'd been by what we'd seen. I dropped the sponge in the bucket and went around back where Lily lay by the pool.

"What about Sebastian?" I said.

She shielded her eyes from the sun. “What about him?”

“He must know film people. He knows Reiner, not that I want you anywhere near that man, but surely Sebastian knows others.”

“I’m avoiding Sebastian.”

“How badly do you want this?”

She let loose an exasperated sigh. “I thought of him right away but that business with Leo makes me distrust him now.”

“Is it possible to just stick a toe in?”

She sighed again, sadly this time. “I’m sure you’re right.”

“We’ll meet for coffee. No hurry, whenever he’s in town next. I’ll go with you.”

“Will you? Thanks, Honey.”

I finished washing the car.

Chapter 8

Lily sent a text and got an immediate reply. Sebastian was in town already. He was happy to hear from her and said coffee sounded great. He said to invite me.

We picked a busy Starbucks near the Strip. He pulled up in a 1956 Alfa Romeo Giulietta Spider, convertible, slate. Heads turned. He wore aviator sunglasses and a maroon scarf despite an air temperature of ninety-seven. He still sported the slicked-back black hair and a Balbo cut on his mustache and goatee. Fingernails painted black and a single silver-rod earring dangled. He also wore tan linen pants and a brown hemp shirt and he looked fucking smashing.

We stood as he approached the table and hugged.

For thirty minutes, we all talked about how we’d spent the last few months. As Lily mentioned her attempted switch from stage to silver screen, Sebastian placed a hand over his heart.

“You did this without me? Why?”

Lily was appropriately sheepish. “I don’t know. Wanted to make it under my own steam kind of thing, I think.”

“How’d it go, Doll?”

“It did not. It did not go.”

He rolled his eyes at me. “I can appreciate that, I really can, and more power to you. But Hollywood ain’t Broadway. Can I make a few calls

on your behalf, Darling? Just open some doors is all. You'll need to do the rest."

Lily looked at me.

"Okay," she smiled.

I marveled at her ability to make it seem Sebastian did her the favor and not the other way around. Conversation moved on to other topics and we all small-talked until Sebastian made a comment about interviewing some handsome well-hung hopeful for an upcoming play. I laughed.

"Jesus, Sebastian," I said. "The percentage of well-hung guys around you is ridiculous. Knowing you gives a guy a complex. Big dicks are supposed to be rare."

He laughed softly. "Occupational hazard, I suppose."

"Living the dream," Lily added.

"I'm a lucky man," he said. He leaned over our table. "You know, there is no x-ray machine on earth more powerful than my casting couch. I see them all, so hopeful, so desperate. They'll do anything for fame. I sift through the most beautiful people with the most beautiful bodies. Of course I'm surrounded by big-dick studs, Luke. I pick from thousands. Unsolicited videos, phone calls from colleagues...if some associate interviews someone that matches my criteria, they pass them along. I spent almost thirty years building this network. Why would I settle for less?"

"It's good work if you can find it," I joked.

"Truly."

"Hey," Lily teased. "I'm fine with Sebastian's access to hung guys."

We laughed. Sebastian played with his car keys for a moment, pondering. At last he said: "There is a conversation we're not having, a topic we've all carefully avoided."

Uh-oh, I thought.

"What did you think of the wedding?" he asked.

"Was that Violet up there?" Lily asked.

"It was. You have a good eye."

"She has two husbands now?"

"She does. And Reiner now has seven wives."

"Seven?" I yelped. "Good Lord."

"Yes. It's up to the women but they keep joining him."

"What does he do with seven?" I asked. "Wait. Never mind."

"Indeed. The man's insatiable. A beast."

“Is Violet happy?” said Lily.

“That’s my understanding.”

“What about Alex?” I said.

Sebastian grinned. “Alex has discovered a voyeuristic side he was previously unaware he possessed. Let’s just say he continues exploring it.”

“How did you manage the church?” I said.

“Basilica. The bishop is an old friend and has peculiar tastes, which I see sated. Beneath the surface New Orleans is a network of canals, tunnels, and caves. Moving people in and out secretly was no problem.”

“I’ve never seen anything like that ceremony,” Lily confessed. “I was mesmerized.”

“Excited? Aroused?”

“Yes...along with mildly nauseated and disgusted.”

He chuckled. “Not for everyone.”

“Did I see Jay there?” Lily asked, cheerfully.

Sebastian stiffened. “I certainly hope not. Your good eye is too good.”

Conversation again swung back to the more mundane.

A gnawing desire to ask about Leo had begun to rise in me but I fought it back. Nothing but darkness down that path. We continued talking until he announced he had another meeting coming up. We again stood and hugged and promised to stay in touch. His roadster roared from the parking lot. Lily and I headed for home.

The next day Lily got a call to come read for a part in an upcoming Vin Diesel movie. She promised she’d be on time. She hung up and stared at me.

“That was fast,” I muttered.

Chapter 9

I woke but didn’t know why.

Lily slept soundly next to me in our bedroom. I lay a moment, waiting, wondering, and decided to go back to sleep.

This time, I heard the glass crack.

I lifted my head and saw a silhouette pass across our bedroom window. I withdrew the loaded Ruger from the nightstand holster, rubbed my eyes, and slipped from bed. The shadow next appeared on our bathroom

window. I grabbed my high beam flashlight and stepped into the restroom, keeping my eye on the window and Lily out of my line of sight.

The window quietly slid open six inches, jammed, and then slid another ten. Big male hands came through the opening, ready to pull themselves into my house.

Let him get inside, I reasoned. Bodies inside are easily explained.

The outline of a head appeared and then shoulders, cautiously working himself through the gap. He handled the toilet well, maneuvering one leg and then the other. I raised my pistol and hit my high beam.

Leo Mason, very much alive, shielded his eyes from the glare and growled, "Put the gun down for fuck's sake, it's me."

Despite my surprise, I did as he asked and quickly shut the bathroom door.

"Jesus Christ, Leo, I thought you were dead."

"I am dead, at least that's what I want Jay and Sebastian to think. Can you aim the light away from my eyes please? Thank you."

He looked gaunt, tired, and angry.

"You hungry?"

I don't know why that was my first question. He gave me a funny look.

"Starved."

Most of my brain had concluded him dead but a tiny part had held out hope. That part now strutted around inside my head, crowing.

"Let me wake Lily," I said. "I'll come back for you. Shut that window and lock it."

I quickly slipped through the bathroom door and closed it behind me. This was crazy. I was sure we were about to hear a wild story. I approached the bed and gently nudged her shoulder. She woke slow and then all at once.

"What's wrong?"

"Nothing," I said, reassuringly. "Everything's fine. Leo is alive and hiding in our bathroom."

"Alive? Alive!"

"Yes, alive and desperate."

Her eyes darted down to the gun still in my hand.

“Yeah. I’ll put this away in a minute. I’m going to the kitchen to feed him.”

Normally a deep sleeper, she was coming around quickly.

“I want to see him. I’ll come with you.”

She threw back the covers and spun her feet to the floor. The blankets knocked over a small statue of Falstaff on her nightstand, an award she’d received for her role as Mistress Alice Ford, from Shakespeare’s *Merry Wives of Windsor* .

She wore a thin, pale pink camisole and matching panties. I thought she’d pull a robe on but when I moved to the bathroom she followed as is. I opened the door.

When Leo saw her, his face softened.

“Hey, Lil,” he said.

She moved past me and now they were hugging like old friends after the War. He kissed her cheek, she squeezed his neck.

“I thought you were dead,” she said, hugging fiercely. “We both did. Your wife has a detective looking for you. She must be worried to death.”

Leo stiffened and moved Lily back to arm’s length.

“My wife hired no detective. She is dead and has been for a long time. I hope you told him nothing.”

My wife and I looked at each other.

“We told him nothing,” I said.

“Then, who hired him?” she asked.

“Sebastian?” I suggested.

“More like Jay Pritzker,” Leo said. “Sebastian’s a bastard but Jay is psychotic.”

I remembered food.

“Let’s feed you. Tell us everything while you eat.”

We all moved to the kitchen. Lily walked with Leo ahead of me, holding his hand and occasionally leaning into his arm. I shut all the blinds and set the dimmer switch to low. The refrigerator light turned her lingerie transparent and Leo got a wolfish look in his eyes. She acted like she didn’t notice but not even Lily is that good an actress. I pulled out every leftover we had and Leo dove in.

While he ate, he told us what happened.

Just before he resigned from my company his wife died in a car accident that the cops said was accidental but freakish. Leo suspected

tampering and took the car to one of his mechanic buddies who agreed. Leo could prove nothing but he knew her death was a warning, so he went rogue.

“They’re furious with me, for many things, but if they’ve gotten to the point of murder I knew it was time to run. I’d broken the rules so many times they finally had enough.”

“Was the recording of Lily the last straw?”

He scoffed and then laughed. “No, stealing files from Jay was.”

“Files? What kind of files?” Lily asked.

“You don’t want to know. I don’t want to involve you guys more than I have, but I’ve nowhere else to turn. They think I did you wrong so here is the last place they’ll look. They have all my friends staked out.”

“I’m happy you’re alive, Leo,” Lily said. She reached across the table to rest her hand on top of his. “And I’m sorry about your wife.”

“Thanks.”

He continued his tale of the last few months, running, hiding, trying to survive. I watched Lily’s face. She looked at him with affection and more than affection. I guess that made sense considering the intense and passionate sex they shared, but I didn’t like it.

“What can we do for you?” I asked when he paused to take a bite.

“Money. Cash. Food and a shower. Maybe a place to crash for a day or two?”

“You got it.”

Lily looked relieved.

Eventually he shared everything that had happened to him since he first ran. He asked how we were and we told him. When we got to the part about the ritual under the basilica, his face turned serious.

“Was Jay there?”

“I think so,” Lily admitted.

“Did he see you?”

“No. He never even looked our way.”

Leo nodded his head thoughtfully, chewing.

“Does your pentagram tattoo mean your wife took a turn on that coffin?” Lily said.

Leo froze.

He returned an apple to his plate. His eyes were pained as he faced my wife.

“Yes.” He took a long drink of water before continuing. “Each time I disobeyed them, they punished me and each time the punishments got worse. As a last resort, they brought me to that basilica. They’d secretly flown her in from Vegas. I didn’t know until she dropped her veil while standing on the altar. Good thing they had me cuffed. I thought I’d go insane watching that. Afterwards Gloria said she loved it but I gotta believe that was the drugs talking.”

I had an epiphany. “Was Jay her second husband?”

He knew what I meant. He looked down at his plate.

“Yes.”

We sat in silence, each with their own thoughts.

“Can I get that shower now?” he said, finally.

“Sure.”

I left the gun on the table and led him to the guest bathroom. I checked on clean towels and toothpaste. There was an unopened toothbrush in the medicine cabinet I told him he could have. He shook my hand meaningfully. I heard the shower start behind me as I left.

Lily still sat at the dining table. “He thinks they killed his wife.”

“He knows they did.”

“Who are these fucking people?”

I remained silent.

“I’ve known Sebastian a long time and I knew he was eccentric but murder? Jesus. And Jay; I had sex with that man. A lot of sex. I admired him and the wealth he’d built. Now I learn he’s just some sicko? Mind-boggling.”

I took Lily’s hand.

We talked about arrangements for the next few days, how we would hide Leo yet still get to work, and if Lily should still go to that audition for the Vin Diesel movie.

“I must go,” she said. “We can’t suddenly do things differently. We’ll look suspicious.”

We sat another minute.

“I’m going to check on Leo,” she said.

Every alarm in my head rang at once. She withdrew her hand from mine and floated away from the table. I heard her footsteps on the stairs and then overhead down the hall and then a knock, soft voices, the shower turn off.

I waited.

Bodies hit the wall. A moan drifted down stairs.

I controlled my pace but moved quickly upstairs until I approached the bathroom door. I heard Lily gasping and moaning.

“Fuck me, Leo. God, look how big it is. I’d forgotten.”

“The fuck you did,” he snarled. “I saw that look in your eyes.”

“What look?” she teased.

“The look you always get when me and my cock come around.”

I peeked through the crack between door and wall.

Leo was backed against the bathroom counter, hands on either side. Lily crouched in front of him, Leo’s heavy cock lying across her face. Her camisole lay crumpled on the floor next to his towel. His dusky Latino skin created a sexy contrast to her white Irish skin. My wife nuzzled his immense balls.

“Did I ever tell you I described your penis to Luke before I knew you? I called you a donkey-dick. You fucked me at Sebastian’s party.”

“I fucked you good.”

“Yes, you did.”

She reached her tongue under and tickled his anus. He opened his legs.

“I want you to fuck me like that again,” she said.

Leo ran his fingers through her hair and stopped. He lifted her head until his dick aimed at her mouth.

“Open up, bitch.”

She did, eyelids drooping with delight. He pushed half his cock towards the back of her throat. Her jaw opened wider. He held her head and flexed his hips, fucking her mouth.

“Soy un burro,” he chuckled. “I like that.”

Lily vacuum-sealed her mouth around his shank and began to bob her head. As he stiffened he rose and as he rose so did she.

Leo leaned back for a better view. “Hold your hair back so I can watch my cock slide in and out of your mouth. No, use both hands.”

Lily lifted her long hair up and out of the way. Like Leo, I watched his cock slip in and out of her salivating mouth. She struggled to go deeper every time.

She looked pretty. With her hair back like that I saw her face perfectly framed and she was gorgeous. The big cock moving in and out

made her sexier too.

“Choke yourself on my dick,” he said. His tone was flat. He did not raise his voice. He simply gave her an order expecting she’d obey and she did, moaning with desire over his force of command.

I could never fuck her like he does.

He let her worship his erection until spit dripped to the floor and rigid veins lined the length of him, then he gripped her hair once again and pulled her to her feet. He made her face the mirror and bent her over the sink and moved behind. His throbbing spear yearned to strike. Still holding her hair, he dipped his hips and pierced her cunt. The groan of utter satisfaction that spilled from her gave me shivers. He sank his cock in without stopping, proof of her arousal, until his big balls covered her clitoris. She was on her toes, face close to the mirror.

“Watch me use you,” he ordered. “Watch that pretty girl in the mirror get fucked.”

Lily braced her arms against the glass and stared into her own eyes. Neither of them knew I was watching. I’ve watched him fuck her before but not for a long time and then seemed different than now. This time, neither of them put on a show for me. This was pure. I saw on my wife’s face how she longed for this man inside her, his big hard cock shoving her around, widening and lengthening her tunnel, compelling her pussy to accept him. She loved it. She loved his cock. She loved getting fucked by Leo.

Her passion is my passion. I shoved my pajama bottoms down and jacked off watching every detail. Her face was twisted with pleasure and I realized with a start she already resisted an orgasm. My wife was trying *not* to cum. His cock was so good that after only minutes she was already there. Amazing.

Each time he withdrew she came down on her heels but each time he thrust she rose to her toes again. He had much more cock than she had pussy and he never buried the last few inches. He sure tried though and that’s what drove her insane. She loved the way he so physically dominated her. He overwhelmed her with cock.

“Jesus!” she gasped.

He gathered more of her hair and began to stab harder. Her efforts to resist crumbled quickly.

“Leo, Christ, I fucking love it. Pound me you bastard.”

Leo left one hand in her hair and moved the other to her waist. He bit down on his lips and began to fuck my wife with vengeance. Or was it longing? Her pussy clung to him and he stretched her lips like taffy.

I was stroking rapidly when he said: "Fuck this, where's the bed?"

I backpedaled fast, clearing the corner as they exited the bathroom. Lily hurried to the bed and assumed a head-down, ass-up position. She turned to watch him over a shoulder. He sauntered towards her, his meaty cock a lance leading the way. She reached under and parted her labia with her finger.

"Hurt me with it," she said.

His face got serious.

In a flash, he was on the bed behind her. He slapped her ass hard, the sound hanging in the air for an instant until replaced by her yelp. He delayed only long enough to align his big head with her tiny hole and then he rammed that steel beam home. Her head snapped back and a cry of pleasure mixed with pain filled the room.

"I know Luke heard that one," he laughed.

Lily said nothing, gathering comforter in her fists as Leo began the conquest of her sopping cunt. They share something special. I must admit that. I do not understand it and I know Lily could never be with him in a relationship but some people just have your number and he had hers. While he was fucking her *all* she cared about was him fucking her. She was a junkie for his cock.

He knew it. He set out to show her he knew it.

Leo climbed over her body until his iron cock entered her at a sharp downward angle. Each time he thrust she groaned. He moved faster and faster until she was whimpering into a pillow, overcome by the constant flow of juice and pleasure her pussy produced. Her eyes rolled back. She drooled. He hammered her little fuck-hole until she could no longer hold back and then came screaming and crying and all he did was pound her harder. I saw my wife lose her mind. Her toes were little fists.

"Holy fuck!" he coughed. "Your pussy is squeezing me. Jesus!"

Her body flopped under his and instead of her orgasm tapering off, his relentless assault drove her higher. She screamed into the bed, eyes squeezed shut, and he grabbed her head and pulled it back.

"Let him hear you!" he roared, and Lily shrieked her mind-blowing climax until the walls vibrated.

I spurt jizz on the hallway carpet. I wasn't ready but I couldn't stop it.

He twisted her head and neck and began dropping his weight on her. She must have felt that cock in her liver but apparently, that felt amazing too. My wife climaxed like a banshee for him.

Before her orgasm finished, she felt him swell.

"Oooohhhh, God, Leo, yes, Baby. Fucking pump me full. Let me feel you spurt. I want your hot load in me. I want you in me."

He let go of her head to move to knees and hands. His hips were pistons. On the run, how long had he gone without? He looked down where his cock punctured her body and watched himself move in her. He pumped faster.

"Here it is," he said, his voice almost strangled. "Here. Take it! Ah! Fuck!"

His big balls lifted and surged. That donkey-cock blasted a deluge of sperm inside my wife. They flexed again and again, his moans and groans in time with his rising nuts and the insemination of my wife. She cooed and purred and urged him to drown her, telling him how badly she'd missed him. He drained every drop.

When calm returned, I entered the room. He held himself over her, his arms quaking. She turned when she saw me.

"You next," she said. His soft cock still stuffed her pussy.

"Not here," I said. "There's room for all in our big bed downstairs."

We lay together for a while but nobody spoke much. At some silent signal, we rose and moved to the master bedroom. We put Lily in the middle and closed our eyes.

He recovered faster than me and I was awakened about an hour later by the bed shaking. She was on her side facing me and he spooned behind, thrusting into her tight pussy. When my eyes opened, she leaned in for a kiss and we shared intimate moments while Leo worked his meat. Her body bounced to the rhythm he set. We were kissing, eyes closed, when he erupted inside her again. The sensation was so exciting I got hard again. He passed her over to me.

She was thrilled. I fucked her from behind like he had, my penis slipping and sliding in his wash of semen, until I shot her full as they kissed. Hot.

He took her again around sunrise.

He took her again when she returned from the audition and while I was at work, and then took her again just before I got home. We all ate dinner together but skipped the movie and went straight to bed. Leo and Lily made hot, sexy love next to me while I masturbated. I came in her mouth.

He fucked her *again* just after midnight.

I could not keep up with this guy.

One day turned into two which became three.

They fucked every day and sometimes two or three times a day. Part of me worried but a bigger part ignited to see my wife consumed by so much desire. She was all over his hanging slab of beef. They showered together. She blew him while we watched Netflix. She blew me while he fucked her from behind on the sofa. She was constantly wet and constantly dripping cum. She could not get enough of him, he could not get enough of her, and I could not get enough of them.

Three days became four which became five.

Lily and I had our intimate moments, here and there, and they were sweet and lovely, but mostly we were super-charged for sex and ran with it. I knew so much constant sperm inside drastically increased her risk of pregnancy, but we couldn't stop.

She rarely wore clothes around the house. If she did usually nothing more than a light tank top and no bottoms. She was always available, always ready.

One night I slept in the guest room and listened through the wall. That was an exercise in pure, blinding agony. I was hard as a rock. All her cries of pleasure drove me insane. They were almost directly beneath me and I heard everything. My imagination is a heartless bastard. I came when I heard her cum and I came *hard*. I was dizzy after and fell asleep. In the morning, they said nothing about my night away.

I took a few days to recover from the emotional anguish but then, like a masochist, I did it again. It was an exquisite torment, a devilish suffering. I got so incredibly, painfully erect. I yearned to go be with her but the bizarre ecstasy of my strange heartbreak was too delicious to pass up. I masturbated to mind-melting orgasms.

The practice was too excruciating, too unbearable. I needed to hold this cruelty in reserve, sipping only occasionally. Each time I needed days to recover from the trauma.

Weeks later Leo and I sat at the dining table, talking like best friends. He wanted me to know he wouldn't stay forever, he knew that, and he'd been carefully investigating old friends to find one prudent.

"I travel across town to use library computers. I never take the same route back. I'm careful I'm never followed. I want you to know how cautious I am."

"I appreciate that."

"With a little more time, I can get my life back."

"How, Leo?"

He gave me a funny look. "With a little more time."

Clearly, the man did not want to talk about it. "All right. Well, you're good here for now. I know Lily loves having you around."

On cue, Lily came in from the laundry, dumped a pile on the table, and pointed.

"Sort and fold," she commanded. We got to it.

Chapter 10

I was finishing up a busy workday when it occurred to me I had not heard from Lily for hours. I smirked. No doubt Leo was pounding her into my mattress. We both knew this would not last forever and probably not even last a long time, but it was terribly exciting while it lasted for now. I sent her a quick, 'I love you' text.

I checked forty minutes later and still no response.

The sun was down as I pulled into the driveway. I entered through the garage and found Leo examining the doorknob on the front door.

"Where's Lily?" I asked.

His face was pale.

"Gone."

He stepped back from the door and gestured at the knob. I noticed for the first time the handle was bent, the metal ring around the base, twisted. I moved closer.

"Someone forced this," I said.

"That's what I thought."

I shouted: "Lily!"

"Brother, I got home ten minutes ago and found this. I searched everywhere. She's not here."

“What?”

“Lily’s gone,” he repeated. “Someone took Lily.”

I wanted to hit him in the face.

“Lily!”

I ran to our bedroom but nothing had been touched. Her purse still sat on the bed with her cell phone in it, a green light blinking with my last text.

“Lily!”

I checked the master bath and then ran upstairs.

“Lily!”

I took the outside stairs down to the backyard and circled the pool.

“Lily!”

Leo stayed out of my way. I returned to the bedroom and checked the holster hidden behind my nightstand. The weight of the Ruger felt oddly comforting. Leo waited for me in the kitchen. I paced.

“Tell me everything,” I said. “From the moment you walked in the door until I did. Then tell me everything you know about Sebastian and that fucker, Jay Pritzker.”

He did.

Most of what he said about Sebastian I either already knew or strongly suspected; drugs, prostitution, money laundering, extortion when necessary. Jay on the other hand, came as a complete surprise.

“Along with everything Sebastian is into,” Leo said. “Jay dabbles in human trafficking, white slavery, drug dealing, and a host of other crimes. I’ve talked to guys that say he’s gone so far as to arrange human sacrifices for his devilish rituals. They say as he’s gotten richer he’s come to believe he’s untouchable. Obvious acts of insanity have flared up, causing some of the guys I know to stop working for him and get the hell out of town. He’s a maniac.”

“What are the files you have?”

He hesitated but went ahead. “I downloaded gigabytes of shit off his home computer while I was there doing a job for him. I have people right now verifying what I found. Soon I’ll be able to hang the guy and send him to prison, or at least blackmail him into leaving me the fuck alone.”

“He won’t let you live after that.”

“I’ve got to try something. Gloria was murdered, I know it.”

He pointed at the gun in my hand.

“What are you going to do with that?”

“I don’t know yet. It just feels like I need it.”

He looked doubtful.

“You ever shot someone, Luke?”

“No.” I started pacing again. “Jay is wild about Lily. Loves her. He fucking rented her for a weekend just to pretend she was his wife. Lily mentioned to Sebastian she saw Jay at the wedding ceremony we attended and Sebastian did not like that. I’m sure Jay is responsible for her missing now.”

“I agree.”

“Where did he take her?”

“He’s got three main fronts for his Satanic bullshit; a mansion in New York, a Victorian house in San Francisco that doubles as a dance club, and a mansion in New Orleans. All of them have tunnels beneath that radiate out into the city. On top of that he owns a dozen homes around the country and a private jet to fly him anywhere he wants. He could be in Paris by now. Berlin.”

“Fuck, Leo, that’s not helping.”

“All right, all right. Sorry. Let me think a minute.”

He joined me in pacing around the living room.

“I have an idea,” he said at last. “I know Julio, the guy that fuels Jay’s jet. I say I have a package for Jay and I know he’s leaving town soon. Hopefully Julio is unaware of my so-called death.”

“Call him.”

He wavered.

“What’s the problem, Leo?”

“I went through a lot to make myself dead. This call ends all that.”

“We’re talking about Lily!” I shouted. “Make the fucking call.”

I shamed him.

“You’re right. Sorry.” He held out his hand and I gave him my phone. He dialed and put the call on speaker. Julio answered in Spanish and Leo stuck with it but I know enough to translate for you. Julio seemed unaware Jay was after Leo.

“I missed Jay at home,” Leo began. “So I was hoping to catch him at the airport. Tell him I’m on my way.”

“You are too late, my friend. He flew out about an hour ago.”

“Was this the quick trip to San Francisco?” Leo bluffed. “He’ll be back soon?”

“No man, I gassed him for New Orleans. He called ahead. Didn’t have time to wait for a full refuel. He just wanted me to pump enough to get him to Louisiana. Said he’d refuel there. I aim to please.”

“Did you see who he had with him?”

“What difference does that make?”

Leo knew he’d stepped too far. “None, I guess. Just trying to figure out if this was a quick get-away or a longer business trip.”

That seemed to satisfy Julio. “Whatever. I was working on the Hawker engine so I didn’t see him leave. You want to leave the package with me and I’ll get it to him as soon as he gets back?”

Leo said he’d find another way and not to worry about it and then he ended the call and returned my phone. I was instantly checking tickets prices.

For the next hour Leo and I got our ducks in a row. I called my boss with a family emergency and bought Leo and myself a ticket. We packed and I locked the Ruger in the aluminum travel case I had for it.

On the way to the airport Leo asked what my plan was.

“Get my wife back.”

“Yeah. I know, but how?”

“I don’t know. I need to see what’s happening in New Orleans.”

“He probably has her at his home. She’s probably not at the church.”

“Basilica. So, we land, rent a car, you direct me to his mansion, and we have a look around. He’s not a Columbian drug lord. I don’t expect guys walking around with machine guns.”

“No, you’re right. He has some security cameras and guards but the two-story house is huge and has way too many windows and doors to cover without a small army. Also, this is not the first wife he’s taken and he always gets away with it so his guard may be down. Most likely he thinks you have no idea what happened to her. Even if you go to the cops, they’ll wait twenty-four hours.”

Once we were on the plane we spoke little. After the plane landed, we followed our check-list and rented a car and Leo gave me directions to Pritzker’s place. It was not what I expected.

Only blocks from Saint Louis Cathedral, sitting unprotected on a street corner, surrounded by Bald Cypress trees and hanging ferns, this was

no mansion of Las Vegas or even Los Angeles. Built in a simpler time, the massive home shared a courtyard and parking with the homes around it. The surrounding second-floor balcony had a guard at each end but the number of ways into the building staggered my mind.

“A simple distraction on the patio and we can pick our window,” I said.

“Or wait until nightfall and climb that tree to the balcony at the back of the house.”

“That works too. Actually, I like your idea better. The tree hides everything.”

“After that, we play it by ear,” Leo said. “We search for Lily and once we find her, we get the hell out.”

“Sounds perfect. Let’s hope nothing goes wrong.”

Chapter 11

Everything did.

At night, an upstairs guard was added right next to the tree we wanted to use. Foot-traffic increased tenfold as tourists enjoyed the balmy Louisiana night and jazz wafting through the air. We were further delayed when I realized I’d packed the wrong ammunition for the pistol and had to go buy the right kind.

Leo and I walked a few passes to find a new way in and settled on renting a room at the Gallier House, a converted hotel behind Pritzker’s place, and jumping the wall that separated the two buildings. If Jay had guard dogs, we were screwed.

He did not. We did almost land in a small rectangular goldfish pond, though.

In his backyard, all the trees and shrubs around the house worked to our advantage. We wore black pants and sweatshirts and peeked in each window we passed. We saw a group of four adults, nicely dressed, sitting in a library talking and in another room a group of kids playing with toys, watched by a gray-haired nanny.

“This is taking too long,” Leo said. “How many rooms does this place have? Let’s spilt up and meet behind the bushes by the pond in twenty minutes. That should cover the first floor.”

“Good idea.”

He went north, I went south, moving from tree to shrub to patio furniture, using whatever cover I could. I'd watch to make sure I was alone, then move to the house and peer through the window.

I was approaching a dark window when it lit up. An older gentleman flipped the latch and opened the bottom half and then I saw him take a puff on a cigarette. He exhaled outside, looking through the glass. I waited for him to finish. He flicked the stub outside and closed the bottom half again, but he did not lock it, and turned off the bedroom light. I had time before my return to Leo so I used it.

Less than a minute later I stood on thick carpet and opened the bedroom door a crack. A hallway ran left and right with a heavy door set in the wall across the hall from me. I was about to risk a quick peek down the hall when the heavy door opened.

A man emerged, dressed casually, and behind him I saw stairs down. He shut the door and turned right. Down seemed more interesting than more of the house so I crossed the hall and headed down the stairs. At the bottom, I found a garage with seven classic cars parked along the walls. Three yellow lights burned. A ramp led up to the street. More interesting, I saw a roughhewn tunnel leading in the direction, unless I was completely turned around, of the basilica.

I debated going back for Leo or pressing my advantage and exploring further. The sound of a woman's voice down the passageway made my choice for me. It did and it did not sound like Lily. I couldn't say either way. But hope springs eternal and all that. I wanted it to be Lily so badly I took the chance. Besides, I had the Ruger with me.

The tunnel slopped down and after a hundred yards branched left and right while also continuing straight. I held true. The yellow bulbs were replaced by small red bulbs and spaced much farther apart. My path seemed to be south-west and I liked that because that's where the cathedral lay.

After some time, the tunnel made a sharp left turn and opened onto a canal. A wood pier had several two-man boats tied. A single red bulb lit the area dimly. The walls and ceiling in this area were in bad shape, saturated with water, and fans of debris littered the floor at the base of the walls.

I was about to take a boat to see where the current led when a growl off to my right turned my head. I saw an arch but the light did not extend beyond it. I crept forward, waiting for my eyes to adjust, and then

remembered I could use my phone as illumination. I drew my pistol and my phone, pressing the side button for light.

I faced a caged area, with bars running floor to ceiling. Behind them stood a monstrosity. Like a mix of man and wolf, or perhaps simply all werewolf, a seven-foot tall heavily muscled and furry creature sniffed the air and regarded me. His eyes were intelligent and his body radiated raw physical power. I scanned the bars, doubting their ability to hold him back if he chose to rip them apart.

He was more curious than anything else.

I dimmed the light.

He walked to a section of bars I now saw formed a door and seemed to think I was there to let him out. When I wavered, he braced his legs, feet wide, and tugged on the bars to show me what he wanted.

With his legs far apart like that, a dangling penis, long and heavy, swayed between his open legs. The base was buried in thick fur and his balls were lost in dense hair, but the big, dark-skinned, uncircumcised shaft swung free.

I worried failure to free him might result in his howling in rage but there was no way I was releasing this thing. I turned back for the boat and held my breath. Behind me he rumbled his displeasure but otherwise did nothing.

I took the boat and allowed the slow current to carry me across the narrow canal to another pier farther downstream. Tiny red lights lit this side too. I had three choices of tunnels and took the center because, again, it seemed aimed at the church.

I'd walked a block or two before I heard voices ahead. I slowed, slipping behind a pillar to peer into the familiar vaulted chamber.

Lily, nude, knelt on the marble coffin.

Jay, standing behind her and nude too, sported a large erection. He held both arms high as if in victory. A cassock draped priest stood at the podium.

A ceremony had just ended and some super-rich bastard led some poor soul's wife down a dark tunnel. An attendant helped the distraught husband to his feet and guided him down a different tunnel.

A group of naked individuals watched Jay tower over my wife. The crowd was mostly men but with a couple women, all different ages and races, all staring at the spectacle, seemingly hypnotized by the inevitable.

I consider shooting Jay from here.

Although she waited patiently and no one touched her, Lily's face was pure and absolute ecstasy. Her eyes were wide and wild. Her brow knotted and she chewed her bottom lip. She gazed about the chamber, dazed. Whatever drugs she'd been given had their hooks deep.

But I was in time.

I stepped from behind the pillar, gun aimed at Jay's heart.

"Don't move, you motherfucker," I ordered.

He smiled.

I think he was drugged too. The crowd looked alarmed but only mildly. Not nearly enough for an armed man suddenly and aggressively appearing to wreck their satanic sex ritual.

Jay lowered his arms but the grin remained.

"Lily, Baby, come here," I said.

She sat her naked butt on the coffin and crossed her legs under her, pouting.

Pouting.

Apparently, I'd killed her buzz.

"No," she said.

Jay laughed. "Now you've got a problem."

Some of the crowd started backing towards other tunnels. The priest backed towards a nearby archway and exited the chamber.

"You've got one gun," Jay said. "Six bullets. About twenty targets. Even worse for you, most of the power of a gun is in the threat, and I'm fearless. You'll have to kill me. Can you kill me?"

He walked around Lily and descended the stone steps. His goddamn erection, pointed right at my face, strained against the tight skin which contained it. None of this bothered him at all. I think the power struggle got him even more excited.

"You must be Lily's husband. That's fortunate. The ceremony is better if the begrudging husband is present. It's infinitely more pleasurable to take something from someone who wants to keep it."

Jay was three steps away and moving closer. If I was serious, I needed to shoot him right now. I looked into his crazy eyes and aimed the barrel at his left thigh. I didn't need to kill him for Lily and I to get away, but if I didn't in the weeks and months that followed he'd keep coming after me. He was obsessed with my wife. I had to stop him.

If you think it's easy to shoot another human, you're either wrong or possibly a sociopath. Instead of providing me the rationalization I needed to squeeze the trigger, my fucking brain started considering all the reasons why I should not; serious legal consequences, the life-altering physical maiming I'd inflict, all that blood, all that screaming, what would the others do when I ran out of bullets?

Jay took another step closer.

It was the picture of myself as a loser in Lily's eyes that did it for me. I imagined what was going to happen if he got close enough to fight me. What if he won? How big a failure would I look to her if I came all the way down here and gave up in the end? I couldn't stand the thought. I squeezed the trigger, aiming for his leg.

A loud roar filled the room.

I'll always take pride in the fact that when the moment arrived, I acted. Regrettably, an instant before I fired, shocking the hell out of Jay by the way, a fist came down on my arm knocking my aim away.

One of the crowd had backed away but circled around and jumped from behind my pillar. My shot went into the floor and then I found myself in a fist-fight against two men with a third and fourth joining an instant later. I never fired a second shot. I got some good punches in. I knocked out one man. Then fists and kicks rained down on me. They took the gun away and Jay had them strip my clothing and tie me up with it, including a gag.

They carried me to the podium and sat me on the floor facing the marble block. Pritzker beamed with joy. His cock looked even harder. The crowd gathered again and I thought it looked bigger than before, like a few stragglers had joined us late or the gunshot drew others from adjacent tunnels.

Lily thoughtfully faced me, knelt on all fours, and lowered her head to the marble coffin, leaving her ass high in the air. Her face was now only a foot from mine.

"Who surrenders his bride?" Jay asked.

Through my gag I told him to fuck himself. I pulled at my restraints. Pritzker leaned over me.

"Husband, do you surrender her womb for another's use?"

I couldn't believe this was happening! I'd seen this ceremony once already and swore Lily would never go through it. I remembered Alex's

agony in my place. I called Jay a piece of shit and a motherfucker again, but of course the gag turned my shouts to mere muffled grumbling.

“Do you surrender her body to another’s touch?” he asked, gloating. He stepped forward to show me his hard-on, as gleeful as a twelve-year-old boy.

“Do you surrender your sole position?”

I screamed no into the gag.

“Lily, do you accept my mounting?”

He said it to her but his eyes were on mine.

I pulled on my bindings but they’d tied my ankles to my wrists behind me and this was not their first time. How many husbands had knelt where I now knelt? How many husbands had watched as their loving brides were taken from them? I thought my heart would burst. Jealousy and helplessness turned into rage. I scanned the room, hoping to find Leo lurking in the shadows, ready to save the day, but I’d left Leo and forged ahead, thinking that pistol was all I needed.

“I doooooo,” Lily purred. She gave me a coy smile and parted her knees another inch or two. Her eyes were aroused but her face dreamy and relaxed. Her mouth parted slightly. “I can’t wait,” she added.

“Bride, offer your slit,” Jay said.

Lily lifted her hips another inch. Jay bent his cock down with both hands and took a step closer. I was gazing into Lily’s eyes when I saw them change as he sank deep; surprise, willingness, shocking pleasure, deep satisfaction.

Goddamn it!

Jay held her hips and began a methodical in and out. Lily’s dream state rapidly fell away and became a powerful and rising erotic charge.

“Oh, God,” she gasped. Her mouth opened wider. “Oh, GOD!”

The skin between her eyebrows knotted and her lips twisted. Jay has a big dick but I knew that alone could not give her this much pleasure. It had to be the drugs. Jay grunted something about how tight she was, staring down at his vanishing cock. He worked her pussy smoothly.

Lily spontaneously orgasmed right in front of my face.

One second she was savoring the full firmness of Jay’s cock and the next, shocked and surprised, her hips jerked and her head fell and a long, loud cry filled the chamber. A murmur of excitement swept the crowd and Jay fucked my wife faster.

After a while Lily's head came up and I saw she was lost to the mind-blowing sensations of sex. She held nothing back. She drooled onto the coffin as Jay's wide cock stretched the tunnel of her pussy. She was so wet I heard him splashing behind her. He laughed like a conquering Roman, hammering and staring down at me, savoring my helplessness and my failure to stop him.

He grabbed her head and pulled until I saw her big, bouncing tits and writhing stomach. Her breasts heaved, her body trembled. He rammed his stiff flesh horn into her over and over and each time my wife gasped from intense pleasure. He owned her and she knew it and she wanted him to own her and that drove her to another powerful climax. She had no defense or resistance to his penetrating cock.

He ordered her onto her back and the speed which she moved to comply bruised my ego. She opened her legs wide, gripping them by the thighs, spreading her sweet flower to his gaze. He looked wild. He looked insane.

Now that she was on her back, I saw clearly his wet and gleaming spear. He'd probed her deep with that weapon and I knew he'd be buried when he ejaculated hundreds of millions of sperm inside her. My entire body ached at the reality of that. I was powerless to stop him. He would inseminate her and remain swimming inside her for days. The thought filled me with madness. I fought against my bonds for the millionth time to no avail.

Jay crawled over and Lily eagerly reached down to guide him in. Her loud sigh told me he traveled the depth of her. He fucked her hard and her arms and leg circled him like a welcome lover. They kissed passionately only inches from me. Jay drove his cock deeper and harder and Lily came yet again, kissing Jay passionately, just as she had on his yacht an age ago.

Perhaps the drugs she'd been given were less a factor than I believed? Perhaps my wife craved the touch of this good-looking, successful, and dominant man? Maybe this driven champion appealed to her in a base and primal way?

The strength and meaning of her kisses certain seemed to say so. She fucked Jay as hard as he fucked her.

"Cum in me," she hissed. "Let me carry you. God! Shoot it deep. Let me feel your cock swell and your hot load gush. Cum in me, Jay. Empty those balls."

Her words got to him. Jay's face screwed up and his breathing turned ragged. He lifted his face away from her kisses to look me in the eyes. The gloating I'd seen earlier returned. He continued to pound Lily but now his eyes narrowed. His face flushed red.

"It's rising," he grunted. "Here comes my load. Take it, beautiful Lily. Take it!"

His mouth flew open and his body tensed. His back slowly arched and then he was yelling gibberish and flopping between her legs as his cock sprayed cum everywhere inside her. He laughed insanely. He groaned and shook. Lily hummed like a well-fed carnivore. His cock spit and spurt and injected until at last his hips calmed and his body slowed.

The room was tense but still.

Jay laid on top of my wife for a long time but eventually rose and stepped aside. He pointed at an older black man in the audience and said:

"You."

I groaned when I saw the man was already erect as were all the men in the crowd. The display they'd just witnessed had affected them all. The man climbed the steps and Lily smiled softly, willingly parting her legs to make room for him. He lined up and sank his black cock deep.

My heart shattered.

He fucked my wife with enthusiasm. The others gathered around and Lily reached for erect penises everywhere. Her mouth closed on one as her hands closed on others. She even curled her toes around two. Those men used their hands to help Lily jack them with her feet and one quickly shot hot cum all over her pretty toes.

A woman slipped under and began licking Lily's asshole while the black man drilled Lily's pussy. The woman pushed a finger up Lily's ass and began to finger-fuck her and my wife soon climaxed *again*.

The black man lasted only a while, too excited by fucking this famous beauty. His dark shank spit cock juice deep to mix with Jay's. Jay laughed with delight as the man shot Lily full.

"May the better sperm win!" he yelled gleefully.

The black man pulled his creamy cock from her tight folds and staggered back. His dark penis was covered with semen and Lily's excitement and as I looked at it a very strange thing happened; my dick started to rise.

I could not believe it. I looked down in shock. I tried to twist my body to hide it but Jay saw and stepped around to point.

“Her Worldly Husband approves!”

Others turned to see what he meant and smiles flashed all around. Lily twisted her head too and I was undone. I saw confusion and disbelief flash across her face and then liberation. My erection was her ticket. She robustly attacked the men fucking her, thrusting and sucking and jerking with abandon.

“Fuck me!” she cried, allowing the penis in her mouth freedom for a moment. “All of you; fuck me. Fill me. Cum in me! FUCK ME!”

Some had held back because I was there and some had held back because in their eyes she was Jay’s woman and some had held back because the situation was not completely right in their mind. All that hesitation disappeared. The pride of lions fell upon their prey and devoured her.

They ravaged my wife, biting and licking and sucking and fucking. One man turned her hips to the side and worked his cock up her ass. She cried out but urged him on. They fucked her in every hole, cumming whenever their orgasm hit and then falling away to make room for the next man. Lily lost her mind and I grew rock-hard, unable to act, able only to watch. My balls throbbed, craving a release which would not come. My upright penis twitched in my lap.

One by one they emptied themselves into her. Some wandered away to watch, some wandered away down a tunnel, finished. Some got hard again from the sight and fucked her a second time and some even managed a third. She was a star of the stage, after all. On and on it went. Lily was awash, soaked and saturated with sperm and sweat and pussy juice.

Yet still we were not finished.

After the last cock ejaculated and the last erection fell, Jay signaled and the two women approached carrying a small wooden box. I was confused for a moment but then I remembered and threw my strength at my bindings again.

Out came the primitive hammer, ink, and needle, and the ladies set to work tattooing Lily, giving her a small, inverted pentagram just above her pussy. She had been so fucked to oblivion she was barely aware what was done to her.

Next, several men lifted me to the coffin and held me down while the ladies did the same to me. I tried to fight but it made no difference. The

women dipped the needle into the black ink, set the point to my skin, and tap-tap-tapped until the onyx fluid pierced deep. It hurt but I was wounded in a far deeper way than my skin. Jay had stamped his mark on my mind. The crazy fucker seared his brand onto my psyche. I would carry both marks to my final day.

More people trickled out of the chamber. The ladies finished, closed their kit, and departed. Lily roused some, enough for Jay to tell her to rise and join him, and then he fastened a dog collar around her throat and led her from the room on a leash.

Lastly, the four men holding me backed away. They debated whose responsibility I was and one of them mentioned the seriousness of kidnapping and so they abandoned me, leaving me bound atop the cold marble slab.

Alone, I sawed my bonds on the edge of the marble coffin until they frayed. I freed myself in about an hour. My shirt was ruined but my pants were intact so I put them on as well as my shoes and socks. While getting dressed I noticed a glint of silver in the dirt and debris and discovered my forgotten Ruger.

I decided to find Leo. If he'd held the gun instead of me, Jay would be dead and we'd be finding our way out of this house. I left using the same tunnel Jay had taken.

Chapter 12

I knew I was lost when I approached the werewolf kennel from a different direction. He smelled me before I saw him and waited by the door as I drew near.

I'd taken Jay's tunnel but had quickly faced multiple intersections, doorways, and stairs. Clearly, I'd chosen poorly somewhere.

I thought about setting this beast free just to cause a commotion but his fangs and claws changed my mind.

"Sorry, puppy," I mumbled, trying to lift my spirits. "I must leave you caged."

At least now I followed a known path. I retraced my steps to the garage and then up the stairs to the main house. I paused at the hallway and then crossed to the room and out the window. I was burdened with every step

I took. Jay had Lily. My wife dripped cum from dozens and I'd failed to prevent anything.

When I got to the goldfish pond Leo almost assaulted me.

"You fucking *asshole!*" he groused, his voice low and strained. "I waited for you. I almost got caught *twice*."

He noticed my lack of a shirt for the first time and then the small tattoo.

"What the fuck happened to you?"

I rasped the story quickly and watched his rage grow.

"Why didn't you just shoot that fucker and anyone else that came at you? Why bring a gun if not to shoot people?"

I had nothing to say.

He waited and then sighed. "It's all right," he said after a moment. "You're a good man, Luke. A better man than me. Maybe I should carry the gun?"

I handed it over.

We returned to creeping along outside and peering in windows but saw nothing of importance. We never found a way to gain the second floor and with the labyrinth of tunnels below, a growing sense of futility infected our mood. Two wasted hours later and we once again crouched in the bushes by the pond.

"This won't work," Leo said. "This place is too big and there are too many people here. Jay could have her on a jet back to Vegas by now. I feel like he brought her out for that hurried ritual and that's complete so why hang around?"

"What did Jay do with Gloria after?"

Anger flared in Leo's eyes but he controlled it.

"Flew her to Aruba for three days." He bit off each word. "Then brought her home to me. She was exhausted. He wanted me to see what he'd done, how many times he'd had her. Two weeks later we discovered she was pregnant."

"Ouch."

"Ouch?" he scoffed. He rolled his eyes at me. "Yeah, ouch."

I hated to give up and walk away empty-handed but I saw no path forward.

"What do we do?" I asked.

He stared at the ground. “We head back to our hotel room and use the next few days to finish what we started. There’s nothing more we can do tonight.”

We climbed the wall back to our hotel room. Bitter failure poisoned my mouth. I’d been so close to success but let it slip away.

We ordered food and showered.

“I know a few people in town,” Leo said. “But contacting them ends my charade. If I can discover where Jay will be and when, I can confront him and get Lily back.”

“You mean we.”

“No.”

He spun a chair and sat. “I mean I. This kind of work is not for you. I can’t have you with me. I’ll get Lily back from the monster and make sure he never bothers us again, but you just give me one more thing to keep track of.”

My suspicion he was right kept my mouth shut. I hated that it was true, but it was true. Next time my hesitation might get us both killed.

I’d left my phone behind when we went over the wall and I now noticed a tiny blue light flashed. Who would leave me a message at this hour? I played the message on speaker. Sebastian’s voice filled our room.

“Luke,” he began. “Jay just called with disturbing news and I’m hoping he got it wrong. Do not confront this man, Luke. You have no idea how crazy he is. He takes what he wants and that will include your life. He has Lily but he will return her. Be patient. He gets these obsessions but they pass. Trust me. Lily will be returned to you in a few days. Back off.”

“Fuck you,” I said to the phone. “That’s my wife.”

Leo nodded slowly, understanding.

I dimmed the screen.

“Too much travel and not enough food or sleep has me exhausted,” Leo said. “Both of us. I can’t think straight. Let me get a few hours rest and then I’ll start making calls. This could get ugly fast so I hope you’re ready.”

“I am.”

“Good. Let’s get some shut-eye.”

I lay in the dark, wrestling with my mind. I’d had Jay in my sights. How many men fucked my wife because I couldn’t fire that shot? Images of Lily rolling and grappling with one sweaty lover after the next tormented me. They’d fucked her *everywhere*. I saw so many different cocks

advancing on her, penetrating her, pumping in and out. I saw her tortured faces of pleasure. I heard her cries of climax. What a nightmare.

I remembered my erection.

Shame filled me. What had aroused me? Was my reaction purely competitive in the face of so many other males?

Sleep would not come. I turned fitfully, seeking a comfortable position.

I saw Lily's eye gazing into mine the moment Jay penetrated her; no fear, no remorse, no reluctance. My wife *wanted* Jay inside her. Drugs or not, Lily loved Jay inside her.

I woke suddenly. A bang on the hotel room door had roused me. I rolled over to see Leo's reaction but his messy bed was empty. A glance at the clock showed me five hours had elapsed and the sun would rise soon. I checked the desk and found the Ruger missing. I looked through the peep hole in the door but saw nothing. I waited. Nothing else happened so I cautiously opened the door to our suite.

A bloody Leo fell backward into the room.

"Goddamn it!"

I grabbed his ankles and spun him around to drag him inside. He had two bullet holes in his stomach and his shirt was soaked with blood. I pulled him to the bathroom and stacked towels over the wounds. I grabbed my phone and dialed 911.

Before emergency service arrived, I searched his pockets. I found the pistol, now with only four bullets remaining. He'd gotten one shot off. He'd gone out without me and gotten his ass handed to him. He left a short trail of blood drops down the sidewalk, but then the trail disappeared in the lawn and sprinklers were taking care of that. His route couldn't be traced.

As the wail of sirens grew closer. I concocted a story about Leo being a homeless person randomly pounding on my door and asking for help before collapsing.

Leo came around enough to grab my shirt. He muttered something I couldn't hear so I leaned closer.

"Say that again," I said.

"Falstaff," he murmured before passing out again.

"I don't know what that means but don't worry," I said. "Help is coming."

The ambulance arrived and a cop soon after. I told them I'd been asleep and awakened by a knock at my door. I told them I did not know the victim. I said I thought he was homeless and someone shot him and he came to my door for help because I'd fallen asleep with the light on. He must have thought I was awake.

With no identification on him, the paramedics treated him and loaded him and headed for the hospital. The cop asked a few more questions, took my information, and wished me goodnight. The hotel manager stopped by to make sure I was all right but I thanked him and sent him on his way.

I started my day with a mini-bar bottle of Jack Daniels, wondering what the fuck I did next. Leo was out of the picture and he took his New Orleans contacts with him. I had no idea where Jay might be, and with his vast holdings, he could be anywhere. Lily might be with him or he may have already dropped her back at our house. I knew she'd left her cell in Vegas so contacting her was out of the question.

It was all up to me. I either waited to see what happened, or tried to make something happen.

I called Sebastian. This early I expected the call to go to voice mail but he answered. I stumbled, at first, then righted my ship.

"He has Lily," I stated.

"Yes."

"I am not Alex, and Lily is no Violet."

"No."

"Sebastian, the man is out of control. I'm taking Lily back."

He was silent long enough I worried he'd hung up.

"All right," he sighed. "I'll help, but I must ask you a question and I need an honest answer from you."

"Always."

"I believe you, Luke. You're a good man. I've always thought of you in that way."

I considered thanking him but did not. "Ask your question," I said.

"The files Leo took. He downloaded them to a jump-drive. Do you have it? Have you seen it?"

"No."

"I know Leo started blackmailing you and Lily again and I apologize for that. Did he ever seem protective over something small; a

sunglass case or set of car keys. Search your memory.”

I did as asked.

“Nothing, Sebastian. Mostly Lily and Leo met at a motel room. The few times he came over it was him and Lily straight to the bedroom. He seemed pretty fucking carefree, frankly.”

“Thank you, Luke. Lily and Jay are still at his residence in New Orleans; six-hundred Governor Nicholls street. There are six doors on the south side of the home. Five of them are painted green but ignore those. One door is surrounded by columns and a lintel. There’s a keypad. The code is seven-nine-one-three. Half the guards go home at sunrise. Lily and Jay will be in his bedroom on the second floor, recovering. Be careful.”

“I will. Thank you.”

We disconnected.

Did I trust him? Strangely, yes. Sebastian and I have always been plain-spoken with each other. He was into shady shit but he wasn’t an evil man. Besides, did I have a choice? I sat on the bed another moment and made a few calls. The last one was to the hospital where they took Leo. I got ahold of a station nurse and explained I was the guy that found him. At first she wouldn’t tell me his condition because I wasn’t immediate family but I convinced her and she revealed he was stable but would remain in the hospital for six or seven days. I ended the call with an offer to pay his expenses and a credit card number. She put me through to billing.

Chapter 13

Broad-fucking-daylight.

I’ve never been more nervous in my life. I saw a huge black SUV drive away from the residence loaded with no-neck-having men. I strolled the sidewalk like an early-rising tourist until I reached the columned door. I flipped the panel up, punched the numbers, and twisted the knob when the pad beeped.

Just like that, I was in.

My whole body trembled.

A narrow hallway led away from the door with a broad opening on the right and stairs up at the end. I forced my face calm and aimed for the stairs. As I passed the opening I saw a large kitchen with tired staff

preparing for the day's meals. They glanced at me but I'd known the code so I must work for Jay, right?

At the top of the stairs a hallway, wider than the one I was in, ran left and right. I flipped a coin I my head and took left.

I heard a loud knock at the front door downstairs.

I continued around the corner and saw double doors at the end of the carpeted hall. My mouth was dry as flour, my palms wet.

Deep voices sounded below and I pictured a small group of men talking. I welcomed the distraction for whoever remained in the home.

My hand floated forward in slow motion. The ornate knob turned smoothly. The door swung back on well-oiled hinges. I stepped into an enormous and opulent bedroom dominated by a massive and elaborate bed. I softly closed the door.

Jay and Lily, nude and entangled, slept on top of a pastel green duvet.

I pulled my revolver and aimed at Jay's smug, sleeping face. For Lily. For Leo.

With my free hand, I touched Lily's foot.

She came around slowly but that was okay; I dared not risk her screaming. She stared at me stupidly but gradually the lights came on. She looked at Jay sleeping beside her and extricated herself from his arms. She carefully moved to the side.

Behind me, the bedroom door opened and closed quickly.

Lily's face turned ashen. Her shoulders sagged. I turned.

Sebastian stood with a sleek and sexy black pistol raised.

"Good morning," he said, smiling. "Luke, may I have your pistol?"

Jay awoke to the sound of Sebastian's voice and came alert much faster than Lily. He sat up.

"Well done, Sebastian," he crooned, the eternal smug expression taunting me.

I handed my gun over to Sebastian's outstretched hand.

Keeping his gun on me, he turned mine in his hand and shot Jay with it three times: Boom! Boom! Boom!

Lily screamed as Jay's chest gained three bright red holes. Jay face turned to an expression of utter disbelief. He looked down at the holes and up and Sebastian. His jaw worked as he tried to speak. He pitched face first onto the bed.

I was too stunned to move. Lily hid her face in my chest and I instinctively hugged her. Sebastian flipped the Ruger around and returned it to me.

“You should leave now,” he said, calmly. “The walls are thick but that cannon is loud and no doubt someone somewhere in this house heard you shoot Jay.”

I was still too stunned to move.

Sebastian stepped to the bed and tried Jay’s pulse. Satisfied the man was dead, he moved to a large bookcase against the wall and lifted a concealed panel. He pressed a button and a portion of wall swung open.

“We’ll talk soon if you run or never again if you don’t. I advise you run.”

He closed the panel behind him and was gone.

I was still too stunned to move. What. The. Fuck.

Lily sobbed softly and that brought me back. An emerald bathrobe lay flung over a nearby chair so I wrapped her in it and opened the bedroom door. I led her down the hall to the side door and then down the stairs and passed the kitchen staff. Moments later we were on the sidewalk and headed for my hotel room. At the last minute, I came to my senses and realized I was about to return directly to my hotel room so I kept walking, taking several twists and turns before stopping at a souvenir shop and buying us both New Orleans sweat shirts and straw hats. I took a looping path back to my hotel room and entered as sirens screamed in the distance.

Lily had been a zombie, moving whatever direction I shoved her, until I closed and bolted the hotel room door. Then she buried her face in my neck and sobbed for hours. Jay was fucking *dead*.

For two days, we kept the shades drawn and ate room service, expecting any moment for the cops to kick the door down.

They did not.

Lily explained how Sebastian and Jay argued when Jay took her. Sebastian was alarmed Jay would bring down the entire network. Jay had grown too bold, Sebastian yelled, too reckless. Sebastian had many peculiar clients and Jay had succeeded in disturbing them all. Sebastian warned him to slow down.

“Now I understand,” I said. “Sebastian used me to eliminate his enemy. He drew the guards downstairs with a knock at the door and then

removed the threat using my gun. No one will think twice about him being there; he's there often. Everyone will remember me."

"They'll remember but nobody knows you," Lily said.

I went on. "The police investigation will expose enough dirt on Jay the list of possible enemies will be a yard long. They'll get nowhere. At least, they never find a connection to us."

"Are you sure?" she asked.

I ran everything through my mind again. "I am. My gun's never been used in a crime and my prints are in no database. I believe we are free."

We visited Leo at the hospital and told him everything. Lily was moved he'd tried to help and thrilled he'd taken two bullets trying to rescue her, but she was utterly enamored of me. I was her shining knight, her savior risking everything to free her. She raved about how I just walked in like I owned the place, alone, and took her back. She blamed her behavior at the altar on the drugs and I didn't press it. Jay was dead. What's the point?

We flew home and breathed easy for the first time in a long time.

I was watching a football game and Lily was reading when a thought occurred to me. I hit pause and she looked up. I gave her a quizzical look and moved to our bedroom. She put down her book to follow.

"What, Luke? What is it?"

I moved to her nightstand and lifted the award she'd received for *Merry Wives*. I shook it and heard a rattle. I turned it over. I peeled away a small rubber stopper on the bottom and dumped a jump-drive onto my palm.

Her eyes went wide.

"Are those the files Leo stole?"

"What else could this be?"

"How did you know to look there?"

"When Leo knocked on my door and thought he was dying, the one word he managed to speak was Falstaff. Not only is this little statuette the only Falstaff I know, it's the only Falstaff he had access to."

"Let's tell him we found them when we visit the hospital tomorrow."

Before we left New Orleans, we arranged transport for Leo to a top Vegas hospital. He'd be coming home in a few days. The bullets had passed

through his abdominal muscles and out his lower back, missing internal organs. He was numb down his left side and had trouble walking and gripping but the doctors said that would fade.

Chapter 14

Leo held his enormous erection at the base, pointing it straight up. Lily, standing over him on our bed, looked down, holding her hair back.

“That thing is a skyscraper,” she joked. Then she bit her bottom lip.

As we’d left the hospital the doctor told Leo no sex for three weeks but I knew that rule would get broken. No way these two could keep their hands off each other that long. Leo was still stitched and bandaged but Lily promised to do all the work.

I sat near the bed, ready to stop them if he got hurt.

When we’d visited him in the hospital we told Leo we found his jump-drive and he laughed, weakly.

“Perfect hiding place,” he’d said. “Since you guys are supposed to hate me.”

“Let’s give it to Sebastian,” I’d said.

He’d given me a blank stare.

“Call a truce, Leo. Hit the reset button. I suspect there are things on that drive that would get Sebastian and all his friends in trouble, not just Jay. Be the bigger man and return it to Sebastian. If not, this conflict starts up again.”

“You’re right,” he relented.

“And don’t make a fucking copy,” Lily added.

“You have two options,” I said. “You are living or you are dead. Option one I say I found it in our home and I turn it over. Sebastian trusts me more and has no reason to further pursue you. Since you are dead he calls off the private detective. Option two, you meet him and hand it over. Try to get back in his good graces and maybe even get work when you’re able.”

“You trust that homo so much?”

“I do. He’s smart and driven by intelligence. With the jump-drive returned he has no reason to harm you. You have skills and connections he needs. I’ll bet the PI was all Jay’s idea.”

“I lose all my leverage,” Leo said.

“You have none. As more of those rich maniacs learn what you possess, they all start to send people after you. Those files aren’t leverage, they’re an anchor around your neck, dragging you down.”

We’d met Sebastian all together, all three of us. He was surprised but pleased and thanked us for making the right decision.

“Conflict is bad for business,” he’d said.

That was four days ago. Today Lily had walked out of the bathroom naked and horny. I’d started to undress to take care of my wife and she’d stopped me.

“Let’s take this to the guest room,” she said. “I need something far dirtier than sex with my husband.”

“Oh. OH.” Shades of David.

“Yeah.”

Now I watch as Leo’s cock fills with blood and his eyes devour my wife. Her eyes do the same to him. His dick radiates vitality and health and affects her with a kind of madness. Like an appreciation for jazz, I don’t feel it myself but I understand others do. Lily and Leo have a connection that I just don’t get but I know is real. I wonder sometimes if Lily has an addiction to orgasm and if she’d imprinted that addiction on Leo and his donkey-cock. Then I wonder if I’m thinking too much. He’s a rough-looking guy, not handsome in any way, but that cock belongs enshrined in a museum.

Lily bent at the knee and lowered her wet pussy to his upright shaft. His aim was true and the large head spread her labia wide and then eased in. Lily exhaled with heart-felt delight.

I’d already stripped in anticipation so I lifted my limp penis and began to stroke. He wouldn’t be throwing her around the bed. Not today and probably not for many weeks, but if they could have sex this time, I knew Lily would be in his room fucking him every day while I was at work.

That helped my penis rise.

Leo let Lily fuck herself on his cock. Sometimes he’d forget and try to move too much and shooting pain would stop him, but mostly he remained still and gazed up at my beautiful wife.

My eyes were glued to the joining of their bodies. Leo’s thick cock dominated her small hole, elongating her opening until she was forced wide

enough to accept him. Her pussy was a tight, white-skinned ring around his shaft.

When he cums in her, I thought. Not a drop will escape.

We still played with fire but, God, the intensity that pregnancy risk added to the sex was mind-boggling. We'd not discussed at all what we'd do if she became with child, but we will. Leo and I are both fucking her regularly now.

Chapter 15

An hour ago Sebastian called with an audition for a movie, and Lily accepted. He'd also hinted that since Lily and I bore the tattoo, he could easily find us a mentor.

"Mentor?" Lily asked. "You mean second husband."

"Yes. Reiner has expressed a profound interest in you."

"What happened to Violet?" she asked.

"Nothing," Sebastian replied. "Violet is delightfully happy. Alex has adjusted well. Reiner, as I've mentioned, is insatiable and believes you a singularly rare and precious gem. With Jay removed, he makes his offer."

I was torn. This life sucks us in and pulls us down. Each day we spend in it sees us farther and farther down the path. Where does it end? This was supposed to be temporary, a phase and nothing more.

Lily met my eyes.

Recently, the idea of a second husband and all the rights he'd acquire was a dagger between my ribs. I still found the idea unbearable, but also pleasurable, like listening through a wall to Lily getting fucked, like being forced outside the ring, a desperate man looking in as other men took what is mine.

"What do you think?" my lovely wife asked.

I imagined a ring of nude men around my wife, all erect, all waiting their turn. Reiner was between her legs already, claiming her for himself.

My heart threatened to burst. My breathing turned shallow. The pain was exquisite.

End.

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